

Film/Animated Series – Look Book/Treatment & Script



PhotosynthesisFilm.com

Based on the musical *Turnover: A New Leaf*

by David Quang Pham



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PHOTOSYNTHESIS

Photosynthesis is a plant-based animated musical comedy set in a world inhabited by photogenic plants. The feature follows a cilantro who owns a salon named Rau Ram ("cilantro" in Vietnamese) as she must earn her green card or else she gets uprooted and loses custody of her son Parsley. The series is a sequel to the film and centers more on the kids, Parsley and Pyrus (a good-natured herb and free-spirited pear), as they navigate Dirty City and create chaos with their naive antics and innocent friendship.

The series logline: In the heart of Dirty City, a photogenic young herb and his pear best friend navigate the musical misadventures hidden underneath the soil while scrambling to keep his mother's salon, Salontro, from being uprooted.

Photosynthesis is adapted from the stage musical, *Turnover: A New Leaf*. At the 2024 Philadelphia New Musicals Festival, *Turnover* won awards for Best Book and Director (Aliyah Curry) and was nominated for Best Musical and Orchestrations. It also won the 2024 Great Performances Fellowship Award. Queer Theatre Kalamazoo produced a world-premiere May 16-18 and concerts June 7-8, 2025. *Photosynthesis* is a 2025 Creative Capital finalist and developed in 2025 Sundance Collab and 2026 Cinephilia Workroom.





PHOTOSYNTHESIS (THE MOVIE)

LOGLINE

In a vibrant garden nation of photogenic plants, a determined cilantro must navigate a ruthless weeding-out process to earn her green card before she gets uprooted and loses custody of her curious son, Parsley.

SYNOPSIS

Set in the garden nation of Woodwork, *Photosynthesis* follows Rau Ram, a cilantro transplant striving for a better life for her son, Parsley. In this world, citizenship is literally visible: natural-born plants or transplants with green cards have green hands, while transplants like Rau have red hands that mark them as outsiders. After years of struggling to run a salon in the urban sprawl of Dirty City, Rau faces her greatest threat: the newly ratified Weed Out Act, which authorizes the uprooting of any undocumented plant. To secure her family's future, Rau must decide how much of her cultural roots she is willing to sacrifice to blend in, all while her son discovers a community of "Figs" and outsiders who believe true belonging isn't found in a color, but in a shared garden.

PLOT SUMMARY

Act I (Root): Rau Ram arrives in Woodwork as a young, pregnant transplant fleeing her home, Paddy Kingdom. Eleven years later in Dirty City, she runs Salontro, a salon for plants. She raises Parsley to be "picture perfect" to avoid the attention of Secretary of Garden Security Rhizo Blomquist. The status quo is shattered when Rhizo announces a crackdown on all "invasive species," leaving Rau no time to get her pending green card.

Act II (Growth): Rau enters an alliance with her flamboyant landlord, Malus Crabapple, who runs the neighboring FigLeaf nightclub. While Rau tries to buy her way into citizenship through bribes and performative actions, Parsley befriends Malus's nibbling, Pyrus, a pear who leads him on unruly adventures. Tensions peak when Rau, desperate to prove her loyalty to Woodwork, betrays her own community by handing over a list of undocumented transplants to Rhizo. As a reward, she finally receives her green card.

Act III (Turnover): The government targets FigLeaf for demolition, forcing Rau to choose between her status and friends. In an act of solidarity, she leads a protest that causes her to lose her citizenship. Despite the protest, the building is leveled, but Rau uses her life savings to fund FigLeaf's reconstruction. In the end, Rau finally finds belonging in the thriving garden her chosen family built together, not in a green card.



SETTING

Inspired by Michigan and USA, **Woodwork** has two peninsulas, shaped like a leaf above a tree trunk. The leaf peninsula (UP) has towns like Mt. Woodwork. The trunk (LP) has cities like Dirty City, Woody Holly, the capital, etc. The story is set mainly in Salontro or FigLeaf nightclub in Dirty City. Buildings are often ceramic pots or treelike. Vietnam and Asia inspire Paddy Kingdom. Moss is grass to plants as grass is to humans.

✿ Woodwork (Plants born/naturalized here have green cards/hands)



✿ Dirty City

- ✿ Cantaloupe Outlets
- ✿ FigLeaf Nightclub – owner: Malus Crabapple
- ✿ Rootimentary School
- ✿ Salontro – Rau and Parsley’s home; landlord: Malus
- ✿ Dirtharmonic Performance Hall
- ✿ City Hall



✿ Woody Holly (based on Hollywood)

✿ Herbivore Studios

✿ The Sunshine Garden



✿ Mt. Woodwork

✿ Pyrus's House

✿ Woodwork National Park

✿ Cherry Tree, Woodwork Capitol

✿ The Green House

✿ Department of Garden Security Headquarters

✿ Whiskerskills

✿ Paddy Kingdom (Plants born/naturalized here have red cards/hands)

✿ Adansonia (based on Africa)

✿ Banyan (based on India)

✿ Bereza Federation (based on Russia and Eastern Europe)

✿ Canguro (based on Oceania)

✿ Floresta (based on South America)

✿ Snow Meadows (based on Antarctica)

✿ Tulip (based on Europe)



CHARACTERS

In addition to the principal cast, *Photosynthesis* has an androgynous supporting cast of families, children, and generic plants to be introduced in each episode for the audience to learn from. They can be featured, developed, and/or done away with as necessary.



The Rams

RAU RAM (36) is a resilient cilantro and owner of the Salontro salon in Dirty City. Fleeing conflict in Paddy Kingdom, Rau raises her natural-born son, Parsley, to be the “picture perfect” child to help earn her green card in a nation that views her as invasive. She maintains a shaky relationship with her neighbor, the nightclub owner Malus, but sometimes views Malus’s unruly nibbling, Pyrus, as a necessary friend for Parsley.

PARSLEY RAM (11) is an optimistic herb and only friend of his overprotective mother, Rau. He helps at the salon and tutors at Rootimentary school. Unlike Rau, he admires the Fig community and connects with Pyrus, who challenges his sheltered worldview.

The Crabapples

MALUS CRABAPPLE (50s) is the down-to-earth owner of the FigLeaf nightclub. A Paddy War veteran, they share a symbiotic but conflicted business relationship with Rau, who sees them as unnatural. Malus must confront their own tragic past of parental abandonment by ensuring their teenage nibbling Pyrus finds belonging.

PYRUS CRABAPPLE (13) is free-spirited pear with a flair for troublemaking, often retreating to their pet bee Bombus. After being suspended from Terra Hill Conservatory, their mother sends them to Malus’s for the summer. They soon find an unexpected, fruitful friend in the little herb next door, Parsley, who helps them turn a new leaf.

BOMBUS BUMBLE B is Pyrus’s loyal pet bee. An intellectual who solves puzzles and stings insults in honey ink, Bombus speaks only in unintelligible buzzes, mirroring the experience of many children of immigrants who cannot speak their mother tongue.



Other Residents of Dirty City, Woodwork

MAYOR CANNA BLOMQUIST (50s) is the rotten and fourth wall-breaking mayor of Dirty City. They are Secretary of Garden Security Rhizo Blomquist's twin sibling.

NURSE BIRCH (50s) is Rootimentary School's nurse.

ALTON DANDY (40s) is a real estate mogul who founded All Dandy Properties. They are the feature's secondary antagonist.

SALIX WILLOW (40s) is a therapist from Gongyuan who cannot help but weep. They are Rau's business rival in the wellness industry.

Woodwork Government

SECRETARY RHIZO BLOMQUIST (50s) is the head of the Soil and Plant Protection (SAPP) Agency as the Secretary of Garden Security and Mayor Canna's twin sibling who is always better than Canna. They are the root of suffering for many transplants while being a child of one. They are the feature's main antagonist.

PRESIDENT PUMPKIN EATER (50s) is the President of Woodwork. They are the epitome of a cheater. They live in the Green House.

SAPP AGENTS / OFFICERS, are Woodworkan immigration officers and agents who uproot transplants.

Residents of Mt. Woodwork, Woodwork

THUJA CARPENTER (40s) is the pine tree park ranger with an eye patch who comes from a holiday freak show family.

MUSA PISANG (14) is a music student who goes bananas at Terra Hill Conservatory and is the flute player in Pyrus's band The Woodwinds.

RHUBARB AVAZ (30s) is the Persian Rubab-playing music teacher at Terra Hill Conservatory and Pyrus's sworn enemy due to her insistence on practicing.

Residents in The Sunshine Garden, Woodwork

KEY LIME (8) is a kid who cannot swim unless it is in sparkling water.

MUSAMI CITRUS (8) is Key's friend who mentors them on how to swim.

Other Plant Characters

ACHIRA BLOMQUIST (80s) is a transplant rights activist and the first transplant to be elected to public office, as a senator of San Clay. She is the mother of Canna and Rhizo.



DJ CAULIFLOWER (20s) is the hip-hop and coolest Cruciferous on tour.

AGENT MINNEOLA ORANGE (30s) is a deceased agent during the Paddy War.

LAMI MENTHA (30s) is a minty superstar and businessowner.

ANANAS PINEAPPLE (40s) is a callous piney entrepreneur whose family founded Y n' Pizza chain. They tour around in their food truck.

SUNFLOWER (60s) is a pop rock folk singer who leads The Beetroots, where the guitarist, bassist, and drummer are literal beets.

WOAD (60s) is a spiritual healer of sorts.

Fresh Ground Pepper

PAPA VER

ABEL ESCULENTUS

HELIA

ALLI SHALLOT

JAZZ NOCTURNAL

SCALLI FISTU

OCI TULASEE

TOM SOLAN

KUDZU LOBATA

PIPER BELL

Bugs

BEES, a plant's dog or cat.

BEETLES, musical birds who can chirp melodies to the plants.

HORNETS, a plant's illegal pet tiger.

FIREFLIES, bugs that light up and go paparazzi.

FLEAS, hopping pets often sold at the flea market.



THEMES

Photosynthesis presents the connections that science and plant biology have with society and family. With synthesizing photographs, the series is rooted in the multiple meanings of roots from family roots to rooting for one another in the community to identify root causes of problems and developing solutions to address them.

Why the pear and herb? For Vietnamese dishes, cilantros are a cultural garnish. And pear trees filled David Quang Pham's childhood home in the city of Wyoming, Michigan. The green card is rooted from their relationship with their **immigrant** parents as an American-born son and their family's deep care for green nature.

The series message is that it is okay for gardens to have biodiversity and that plants can live in peace and harmony if we tend to what they need if certain conditions are hard for them to adapt to. The green card element symbolizes **adaptation** and **acceptance**. Green cards, to plants and humans, are not easy to obtain unless you are born into the garden's specific soil. Parsley is a green card holder of UVS, but Rau is not.

With the show being inspired by David Quang Pham's musical theatre background, there are **music lessons** layered within. With anything featuring Pyrus's archnemesis music teacher Rhubarb, the series explores their relationship, showing how the lines between tough coaching and abuse can become blurred. With Mayor Canna Blomquist, we can learn the **nature of power** and influence local governments have on our lives.

With a mix of pop, rock, and Vietnamese folk, the many duets explore the friendships that queer liberation can spark, while the ensemble numbers explore the meaning of home. These story-driven songs and plant-inspired characters teach plant science.

SELECT SONGS (from *Turnover: A New Leaf*)

Links in **Blue**

["Move the Plot Forward"](#)

["A Natural"](#)

["Amount to Anything"](#)

["Photosynthesis"](#)

["Crop Top"](#)

["Soiled \(The Family Name\)"](#)

["Fertile"](#)

["Dirt on You"](#)

["Turnover \(A New Leaf\)"](#)



Photosynthesis Movie

Genre: Rites of Passage (with elements of Buddy Love)

Opening Image: A lonely photo and immigration case file of Rau Ram, an expectant mother on her way to Dirty City, Woodwork.

Theme Stated: "A green card ain't green on the other side." - Malus Crabapple

Rau believes a green card would grant her a place in the nation's soil. It can be as lonesome as not having one. Her photos are just her and her son now, but as they better the community, she will learn what it means to belong.

Set-Up: Rau Ram, a cilantro, emigrates to Dirty City. She could not find a home for her salon business. However, Malus, a nightclub owner and landlord, offers her their spare plot of land. The difference between them is night and day for the nightclub owner and salon owner. She soon has a son named Parsley.

Catalyst: After a dozen years, Rau's green card application is finally up for review. It comes at a time when more "invasive species" are forced out of Woodwork. She's only able to stay in this garden because her son is a natural born citizen. With a green card, she can legally own Salontro and get it off Malus's hand.

Debate: Pyrus, a pear suspended from their conservatory, visits town and stays with their unty Malus. They befriend the well-behave Parsley. Rau sees Pyrus as a bad influence.

Break into Two: Rau could never save up when paying rent. However, Malus strikes a deal that they won't charge them if Parsley is Pyrus's school tutor.

B Story: Rau needs all hands on deck to save up to purchase Salontro, while Parsley plays hooky with Pyrus and does everything they can to hide their adventures.

Fun and Games: Overtime, Rau saves enough to purchase Salontro. Parsley seems queer and weird to Rau. Malus asks Rau to come to their summer solstice retreat. Parsley opens up and asks to hang out with Pyrus as friends in Cantaloupe Outlets. Rhizo Blomquist offers Rau her green card if she gives them her book containing other transplants' addresses. She accepts. She cannot hold this news any longer and goes to see Parsley. She finds Parsley and Pyrus wearing crop tops which makes her lash out.

Midpoint: Rau does this summer solstice retreat to get on Malus's good side in buying Salontro. While on the retreat with Malus, she learns about Malus being kicked out by



their parents for being queer and how they found a home in FigLeaf and their experience with immigrants. Malus gifts the deed to Salontro at no charge.

Bad Guys Close In: Parsley sneaks out. Pyrus has an unlawful rave at FigLeaf that leads to Parsley's hospitalization and their arrest. Dirty City shuts down FigLeaf. Hoping to keep the family integrity, Rau decides not to stick up for Malus and blames their community for "misleading" her son.

All is Lost: Rau keeps Salontro salon, but her son Parsley won't speak to her. She loses her regulars and lives on her savings.

Dark Night of the Soul: Parsley runs away with Pyrus to their hometown of Mt. Woodwork. No one will help even a Woodwork citizen find her son. Rau is alone ("A green card ain't green on the other side").

Breaking into Three: On a calendar, Rau looks at past photos of her and Parsley. It's been a photo of her alone these past many days. She finds the photobooth photo of Parsley and Pyrus. It's the happiest Parsley has ever been.

Finale: In a city auction, Rau almost wins FigLeaf's domain, but All Dandy Properties outbids. Rau squats on the premises, halting the demolition. She gains public support but is alone in a water-hunger strike. Secretary of Garden Security Rhizo and their Transplant Service Officers revoke Rau's green card. Seeing the news, Parsley worries. He returns, making Rau leave her post. FigLeaf gets bulldozed. Rhizo chases Rau into Salontro, but the kids trap Rhizo in a tanning bed. Changed by its magic, Rhizo threatens the developers with legal action for exploitations of transplants. Rau knows she'll have to wait another dozen years for her green card to be reconsidered. For now, she helps rebuild FigLeaf and welcomes Pyrus to the Salontro family.

Final Image: A group photo of Rau surrounded by those who love her.



TYPICAL EPISODE

The objective of each episode is to a) introduce new plant characters; b) connect biodiversity with themes of family; c) explore Dirty City and the state of Woodwork; and d) take photos. The characters can take selfies and photos that will be planted into the end credits of each episode. The photos may also be significant in feature episodes. Every time the characters take a photo, they sing the photosynthesis jingle: “Photosynthesis, photosynthesis, photo!” There will often be at least a song written by David Quang Pham or another songwriter in each episode.

Photosynthesis

(from *Turnover: A New Leaf* by David Quang Pham)

Sugar Rush! (J = 144)

PARSLEY: $B\flat$ Gm^7 $E\flat$ F^7 $E\flat$ $B\flat$ F $B\flat$ Gm^7 $E\flat$ F^7

C 6 H_2 O 6... plus 6 O 2 6 car-bon 12 hy-dro-gen. 6

PYRUS:

Sug - ar, glu - cose, sug - ar, and starch. Your cell - u - lose.

$E\flat$ $B\flat$ F $B\flat$ Gm $E\flat$

ox - y - gen... plus 6 ox - y - gen mol-e-cules. Pho - to-syn - the-sis. Pho - to-syn - the-sis. Pho - to!

GARDEN: $B\flat$

Your cell - u - lose. This is pho - to-syn - the-sis. Pho - to-syn - the-sis. Pho - to!

Photo snaps.

Pyrus often initiates the misadventures through their own wrongdoing while Parsley naively goes along with their best friend. The end of each episode usually shows that it is never too late to do the right thing, even if you have done wrong before. Like many animated series, these kinds of situations lead to a fun or comedic outcome.

There will be episodes on Pyrus and Malus’s relationship or Bombus’s or Parsley and his mom Rau’s relationship. In an episode titled “Behave for a Bee Hive,” Parsley walks by a petting zoo and asks Rau for a pet bee, like Pyrus’s Bombus. Rau accidentally gifts Parsley a hornet, which terrorizes the town. Other episodes will center Rau’s immigrant struggles beyond the difficulties of earning a green card, from cultural clashes and the pressure to live up to expectations.

With any episode that features Rhubarb, Pyrus’s unhinged music teacher and archnemesis, there are music theory lessons planted throughout. The episodes that feature Mayor Canna Blomquist have them get their comeuppance mixed with them being able to slip through scandals.



SERIES DEVELOPMENT

At first, Pyrus has very few friends and lacks body confidence. So, they often resort to bullying to get their way. It gets so out of hand that their parents push Pyrus out of Mt. Woodwork and into unty Malus's care in Dirty City. Little did they know that they would befriend the neighboring immigrant salon owner's son named Parsley there.

Parsley has little time for friends due to spending much of it helping their mom around the Salontro business. He is also treated differently from his classmates due to being the son of a non-green card holder. There is immense pressure for him to live up to family expectations, so Parsley often yearns for adventures away from it. It would make sense for him to connect with the openly weird and queer Pyrus.

Pyrus and Parsley continuously learn that they need each other, Pyrus for adventure and Parsley for moderation. Pyrus grows more well-intentioned and morally ambiguous in their decisions that often turn out bad, like partying or pranking. Meanwhile, Pyrus grows more experimental and unrestrained in their life, often tied down to how they will be publicly perceived as a member of the immigrant community.

Photos taken from each episode will be compiled and displayed for features, used as teachable moments and to chart the evolution of relationships.

Rau eventually earns their green card, but it comes after developing the communal trait of hers. Malus's FigLeaf Nightclub eventually gets shut down due to Pyrus and Parsley. Malus will mentally get in shape when the time comes, so they are able to reflect on their time. There will be development for other adult characters such as the rotten Mayor Canna Blomquist, the insane music teacher Rhubarb Avaz, and the weeping therapist Salix Willow.



EPISODES (SAMPLE)

GREENLIGHT (PILOT EPISODE)

At Salontro, Parsley and Pyrus accidentally give a reality TV producer glamorous Greenlight highlights, landing them a deal with Green Entertainment Television. To save the salon and secure his mother's future, Parsley must fake this miracle for the cameras, only to discover the treatment causes cytorrhysis, meaning their superstar mint client will literally blow up on national TV.

BEHAVE FOR A BEE HIVE

Walking by the petting zoo, Parsley eyes a bee and wants one like Pyrus. Rau jokes if Parsley gets all As this semester they will get a pet bee. Parsley achieves that. Rau keeps her promise, partially. She accidentally gets a hornet from the black bean market, which unleashes terror upon the town. Pyrus calls in Bombus to take down this worthy foe.

BEFRIENDING THE BEHEMOTH (Related Episode)

FIRST PLANT

Cosmonaut Thaliana Rock-Cress and astronaut Dracaena Maize, the first two plants in space, visit Parsley's school, inspiring him to want to go to the Moon.

HAY DAY

MINT CONDITION

Salontro is invited to Woody Holly to be Lami Mentha's makeup team for the reboot of her Mint Condition film series. While visiting the studios, Pyrus gets roped in a music opportunity of a lifetime.

PINEAPPLE PIZZA

Parsley visits Pyrus in Woodwork National Park for their first camping trip together. When a pineapple visits the park with their pizza truck, mysterious incidents occur all about. Should pineapples be allowed to make pizza, even if they lead to the apocalypse?

ROOT WORD

SQUARE ROOT

VOLTI SUBITO (TURN QUICKLY)



Rhubarb Avaz, Pyrus's music teacher and archnemesis, is in town as the seasoned conductor for the Dirtharmonic Orchestra. Malus believes Pyrus can get in her good graces if they apprentice her. Will Pyrus grace the harmony or stand out in the melody?

WEeping WILLOW

Rau cannot burn out. She drinks enough water each day after all. But in comes the only person who can burn her out: a therapist. Salix Willow, a native from Paddy Kingdom, keeps coming into Salontro and striking up conversations that make Rau tremble, revisiting her past in Paddy Kingdom.



SCIENCE EDUCATION IS IMPORTANT

The knowledge of science is important because it cultivates critical thinking skills by encouraging curiosity, questioning, and evidence-based analysis, allowing individuals to better understand the world around them, make informed decisions, and solve problems through a methodical approach. It also fosters creativity and adaptability to change. Think critically and approach challenges with a scientific mindset.

PLANTS ARE IN

People are often drawn to plants as they can significantly improve mental well-being by reducing stress, boosting mood, and enhancing creativity, while also providing a sense of responsibility through nurturing and caring for a living thing; additionally, plants contribute to cleaner air quality and can aesthetically enhance a space.

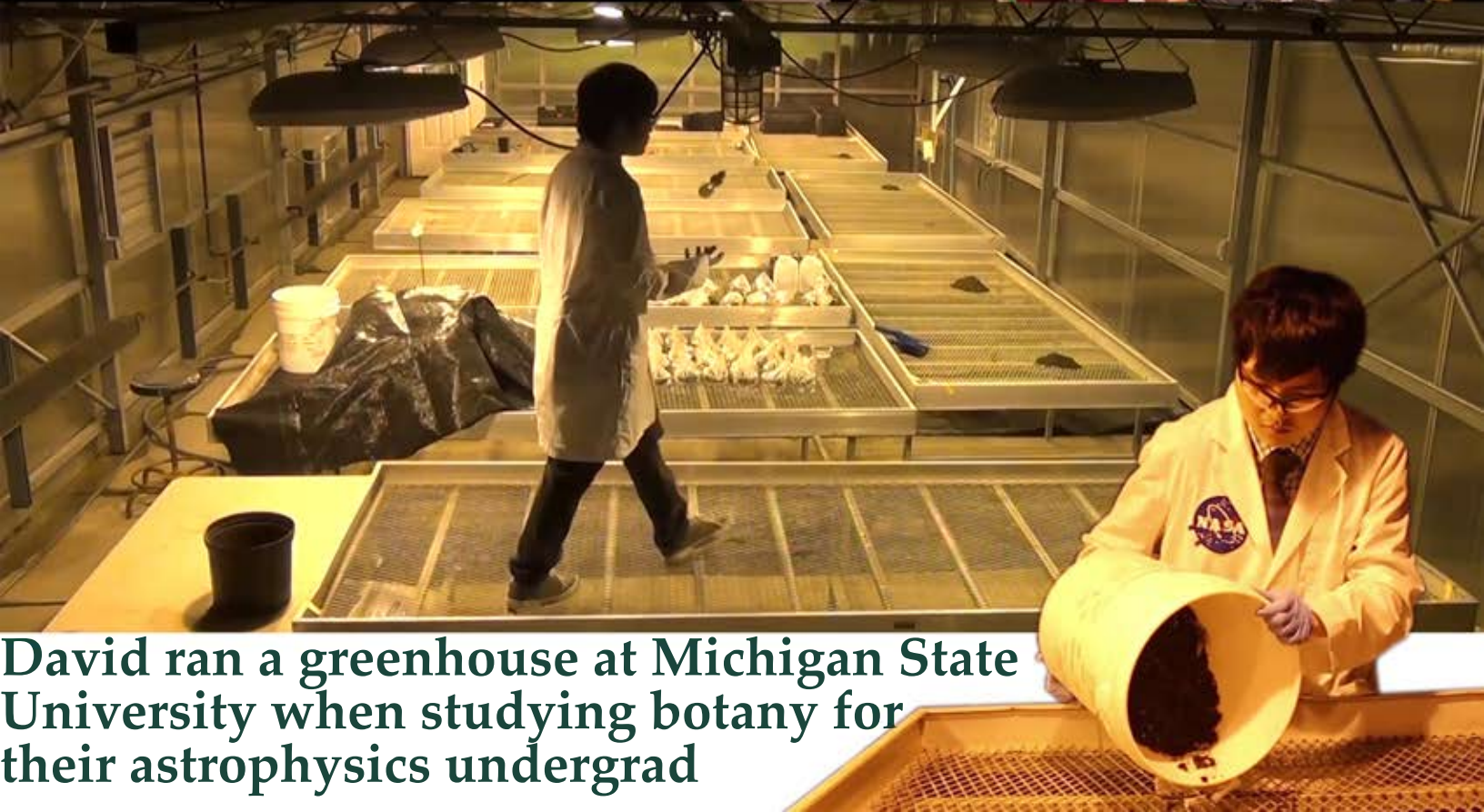
FABLES ARE IN

People are drawn to fables because they offer easily accessible life lessons and moral messages, often conveyed through engaging stories featuring anthropomorphic characters, making them a simple and relatable way to learn about important values and behaviors.

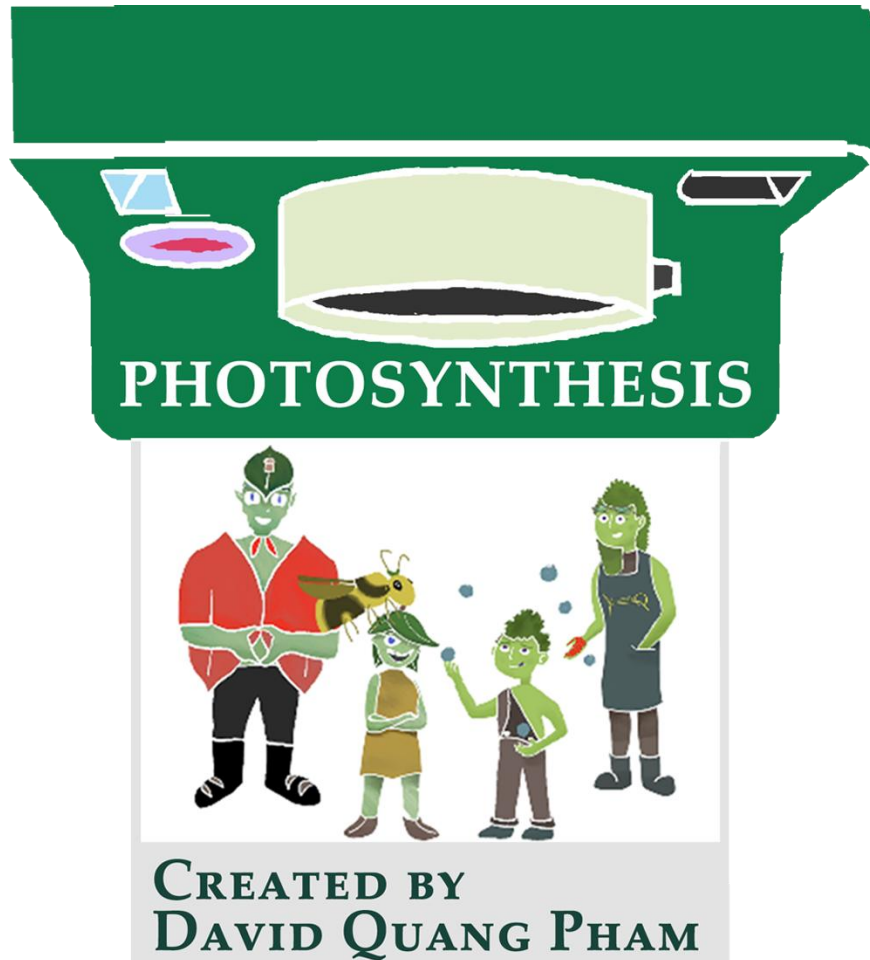
It's *Zootopia* meets *Elemental* meets *Sing*, an animated musical comedy set in a vibrant world of sentient plants that explores complex themes of immigration, identity, and community through the lens of a cilantro family fighting to stay rooted.







David ran a greenhouse at Michigan State University when studying botany for their astrophysics undergrad



PHOTOSYNTHESIS

An Animated Comedy Feature

Written by and Music by

David Quang Pham

Based on the musical ***Turnover: A New Leaf*** by

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PHOTOSYNTHESIS

by

David Quang Pham

Based on the award-winning stage musical

TURNOVER: A NEW LEAF

by

David Quang Pham

Revised Draft
12/12/2025

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PROLOGUE

INT. CUSTOMS, SOIL AND PLANT PROTECTION AGENCY OFFICE - DAY

"OUT OF THE PICTURE" SONG

We see the front of a polaroid camera. We hear RAU RAM with her 25-year-old youthful yet shaky Viet-folksy singing voice.

RAU (O.S.)
SMILE FOR THE CAMERA...

FLASH! The camera prints a photo of Rau with a fake smile. She is a cilantro, with human limbs like all plants in this world. Her earthly hair gleams. Pregnant, she's expecting a new seed.

Her RED HANDS pull the photo into the sunlight.

RAU (O.S.) (CONT'D)
PILED ON BY BAD OUTCOMES
RILED UP FROM ITS CRUMBS
MILES FROM MY KINGDOM
NOW I CAN FINALLY SEE THE SUN...

THROUGH HER CAMERA: Rau leans against a terracotta wall under a banner that reads: PHOTOSYNTHESIS

RAU (CONT'D)
Chào, Woodwork! Coming to your
garden nation is the good-est
citizen you'll ever meet! I'm-

BACK TO SCENE: RHIZO BLOMQUIST (40s), a towering Gladiolus, strides in. They are clad in a dark green SAPP uniform, like armored leaves. Their petals are a bureaucratic pink.

RHIZO
You cannot even speak proper
Woodworkan. "Good-est?" That ain't
a real word. Good heavens. Name?

RAU
Rau Ram. I'm a cilantro from Paddy
Kingdom, *which is far from heaven.*

Rhizo flips opens her file. WOODWORK GREEN CARD APPLICATION:
RAU RAM. AGE 25. CILANTRO. RED FINGERPRINT. STATUS: PENDING.

RHIZO
State your business.

RAU
I am here to open Salontro, the
first salon in Dirty City history!

RHIZO

A cilantro running a salon in Dirty City, huh? A hotbed for transplants. My twin, Mayor Canna Blomquist, is running that sanctuary garden city to the ground. They're a good-for-

RAU

(Reading Rhizo's badge)
Goodness me! Um- Reez-o Blomquist?

Transplants with NON-GREEN HANDS shuffle in. Rhizo sneers.

RHIZO

Rise-o. You can't read either. Let's *sing* a language you may understand.

YOU ARE NO CITIZEN UNLESS YOU...

TRANSPLANTS

...EARN YOUR GREEN CARD!

RHIZO

CAN'T PARTICIPATE IN THE PROCESS
UNLESS YOU...

TRANSPLANTS

...EARN YOUR GREEN CARD!

RHIZO

DON'T INTERRUPT ME UNLESS YOU...

TRANSPLANT

...HAVE YOUR GREEN CARD!

RAU

...EARN YOUR GREEN CARD?

A SAPP Officer hands a green card to a Transplant. Their hands GLOW and turn GREEN. Rhizo slams Rau's file shut.

RHIZO

OTHERWISE, YOU'RE OUT OF THE PICTURE!

Rau reaches for a handshake. Rhizo ignores it and exits.

RAU

WISE UP! THIS PICTURE-PERFECT TRANSPLANT...

THROUGH HER CAMERA: Rau goes to us then turns us to reveal the GATEWAY SIGN of DIRTY CITY in the nation of WOODWORK.

EXT. DIRTY CITY - ENTRANCE - DAY

THROUGH HER CAMERA: Rau poses by the sign as locals scowl.

RAU (CONT'D)
...WILL MAKE NEW FRIENDS!

DIRTY CITY CITIZENS
WHEN WILL THIS END: MIGRANTS?

RAU
AH SNAP! I AIN'T GOING NOWHERE

DIRTY CITY CITIZENS
YOU'RE GOING NOWHERE

FLASH!

EXT. DIRTY CITY - STREET - MOMENTS LATER

BACK TO SCENE: Rau SNAPS photos of the hostile crowd.

RAU
SNAP! I'LL BE HARNESSING SUNRAYS

DIRTY CITY CITIZENS
SHOT! YOU'LL BE GONE BY FOUL PLAY

RAU
NEWS! I'LL BE ON IT EVERYDAY

DIRTY CITY CITIZENS
FLASH! YOU SHOULD PULL YOUR WEIGHT

RAU
THIS MAY BE DIRTY CITY
BUT I WANT IT NO OTHER WAY
I COUNT THE DAYS
FOR THIS TOWN TO WELCOME MY STAY

THROUGH HER CAMERA: Rau comes across the bustling town square. She sets up the camera and poses by the fountain.

RAU (CONT'D)	DIRTY CITY CITIZENS
I TOOK MY PICK	YOU'VE MISTOOK US
NOW I AM HERE AND	YOU'RE WEIRD
NO ONE CAN TAKE ME	WHO PICKED HER?!
OUT OF THE PICTURE!	YOUUU SUURREEE?

CRACK! A local knocks us (the camera) over.

BACK TO SCENE: Rau holds her camera with a protruding photo. The locals turn "Space Available" signs to "Curb the Herb." RAU doesn't belong on this soil. She gazes at the broken lens.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. VILLAGE IN PADDY KINGDOM - LONG AGO - DUSKTHE ACOUSTICS UNVEIL SOUTHEAST ASIAN ANTIQUITY

A wrinkled photo of 5-year-old Rau curls in a fire.

15-year-old Rau watches charred photos rain down from a village on fire. The sky is murky with no sun in sight.

YOUNG RAU
MOM WAS OUT OF THE PICTURE!
DAD WAS OUT OF THE PICTURE!
BRO, HELP OUT YOUR SISTER...

Her brother CORI ANH (17) swiftly scoops Rau on a motorbike. They roar away. As they crest a hill, sunlight hits them. Rau's charred skin heals. She won't take the sun for granted.

They drive by a WOODWORK BILLBOARD. Rau sees herself there.

YOUNG RAU (CONT'D)
A NEW HOME IS IN FRAME...

CORI ANH
SIS, NO ONE CAN TAKE YOU...

The motorbike drives into the sunset.

EXT. FIG LEAF - DUSK

The sun sets as present-day Rau collapses.

RAU
...OUT OF THE PICTURE.

She pulls a photo from the broken camera: her pregnant belly.

RAU (CONT'D)
ALL I NEED IN THE PICTURE
IS YOU AND ME... MY SEED.

END OF "OUT OF THE PICTURE"

MALUS (O.S.)
Mercy?

Rau turns away from the sunset to face a vibrant nightclub.

MALUS CRABAPPLE (40s), a fabulous red apple in angelic attire, leans against the club's door.

RAU
Chào. Aren't you an angel?

MALUS

Hello. Aren't all Figs?

RAU

Hell! Any Fig is a malice!

MALUS

Dat's my name: Malus Crabapple.

(Eying the camera)

A figment of my imagination? Nice lens. I had one just like it.

Malus extends a hand. Rau slaps it away.

RAU

Keep your appendages off me!

MALUS

I gotta hand it to you. You are no angel. You ain't owed a safe haven. You don't belong on our soil.

RAU

Heavens. Your kind soiled safety.

MALUS

And your kind of soil is mud.

RAU

Mud is where you're most safe...

MALUS

Dirty or clean... A green card ain't green on the other side.

RAU

Better than the red cards I was dealt with.

MALUS

But, the other side of the sea had the right conditions for you. There ain't no unconditional love here.

RAU

The Woodwork dream...

MALUS

Is this what you imagined it to be?

RAU

This Cilantro dreams! *Bleeds!* This city needs its garnishes.

(MORE)

RAU (CONT'D)

Imagine Dirty City's first-ever
salon. A better life for my family
is here.

MALUS

You immigrants got wild dreams. *But
imagination*s. Your people cannot
imagine peace with the likes of me.

RAU

You don't know where I come from.

MALUS

Ya tone ain't a *brussels* sprout's.

RAU

I do not have a tone! I went to a
Woodworkan-sponsored school to get
the Paddish out of my system...

MALUS

Well you *look* like you took a leave
from another continent? All your
last names are *weed* (*re: Nguyen*)?

RAU

Răm. Rau Răm. We've got more last
names than you have shades of green-

MALUS

Rau, I won't judge your days if you
don't judge my nights.

RAU

Your fruity "nightlife" is a choice
so unnatural. No one's born with it-

MALUS

It stems from birth, egotistic herb.
You remind me of myself. Keep this
up and your story will end here.

RAU

I cannot keep my stems up. No plot
of land in Dirty City will ever let
me plant myself. I moved this far
for what? My story will... What?

"MOVE THE PLOT FORWARD" SONG

Malus heads to the empty plot next door. They pull the tarp
away to unveil fresh soil.

MALUS
MOVE THE PLOT... FORWARD...
MAKE YOUR ROOTS AT HOME

RAU
THIS IS YOUR BEST FOOT FORWARD?

MALUS
ROOT FOR ME...

RAU
(in Vietnamese; subtitled)
IM LANG
(SHUT UP)

MALUS
MAKE YOUR BED

A tanning bed appears out of nowhere.

RAU
SHUT UP

MALUS
I WASN'T BORN WITH LIGHTHEARTEDNESS
I HAVE CHOSEN IT
NOW YOU CHOOSE:
MOVE THE PLOT FORWARD...

RAU
OR...?

MALUS
LEAVE THE PLOT HOLE...
MOVE THE PLOT FORWARD...

RAU
WHOLE...

RAU & MALUS
MOVE THE PLOT FORWARD...

RAU
FORWARD!

MALUS
YOU'RE WHOLE!

MONTAGE

INT. SALONTRO - DAWN: Rau hammers. The empty plot develops into a salon.

LATER: Rau installs a tanning bed. Malus pays and hops in it.

RAU (CONT'D)
IT'S THE TURN OF AN ERA
I WAS DEALT A BAD HAND
THIS AREA HAS NO REGARD
THEY TREAT ME AS AN ALIEN
I HAVE GROWN THESE LEAVES THAT
COULDN'T EVER HOLD THIS WATER
I WAS GONNA COME APART
BUT I GUESS YOU DO HAVE A HEART
I HAVE A NEW START

Malus gets out of the tanning bed.

MALUS
You're on your own on this soil.
Looking forward to what's next.

Malus turns the sign to OPEN before exiting.

Several TUMBLEWEEDS dance in and out.

RAU
I CAN'T EARN MY GREEN CARD
IF I DON'T STAY ON MY GUARD
MY LEAVES HAVE COME SO FAR
YOU CAN'T MAKE ME LEAVE!
WHAT REMAINS ARE MY ROOTS, FAMILY.

Rau pulls out body oil and rubs her belly with it. It glows.
We hear the voice of a boy not yet born, PARSLEY (11).

PARSLEY (V.O.)
TURN AROUND!

MONTAGE: The sun and moon SOAR through the window. PATRONS
flood the salon. The cash register overflows. The one tanning
bed multiplies into a row of pods. Rau stands, determined.

RAU
My body oil? You like this foreign
stuff? Well, it's no fertilizer!
This oil is not found in Dirty City.
It's from my dirty ol' village!

YOU HAVE MADE IT
TURN AWAY FROM YOUR OLD LIFE
YOUR BED IS MADE
TURN AWAY FROM THEIR WILD NIGHT

THIS DIRTY CITY IS OUR HOME
THE NEIGHBORS, THEY'LL KNOW
TO STAY IN THEIR ZONE
UNLESS THEIR TONE
TURN OVER AND CHANGE FOR THE BETTER

RAU (CONT'D)	MALUS
(Deceptively)	(Doubtfully)
THIS IS THE START OF...	THIS IS THE START OF...
A BUSINESS PARTNERSHIP	A BUSINESS PARTNERSHIP
A "FRIENDSHIP" WHERE I CAN'T	A "FRIENDSHIP" THAT SOWS MAD
KEEP MY GUARD DOWN	SEEDS IN OUR GARDEN

Rau hands rent to Malus, who exits. She flips the sign to CLOSED. She climbs into a tanning bed.

RAU (CONT'D)
BUT THE BEST TURNOVER I'VE EVER HAD...

The tanning bed GLOWS. Rau emerges, no longer pregnant, cradling a seed. It hatches into her baby: PARSLEY.

RAU (CONT'D)
...IS MY SUN!

END OF "MOVE THE PLOT FORWARD"

INT. SALONTRO - DAY

Rau holds her baby's green hands. A teardrop lands on him. He giggles and grows instantly. Rau faces towards the camera.

RAU (CONT'D)
Smile for the camera, Parsley Ram!

Flash! A photo lands: YEAR 0.

PHOTO MONTAGE: Photos slap down in rapid succession. YEAR 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10. With each snap, Parsley grows and Rau ages.

RAU (V.O.)
You may be a natural-born citizen,
but you're still the son of a
transplant. I'll do my best to make
you picture perfect. We'll...

RAU & PARSLEY (V.O.)
...MOVE THE PLOT FORWARD!

Year 11. Parsley is a bushy-haired boy. This photo becomes LIVELY. Rau stands over Parsley, wielding hair clippers.

RAU
But your trichomes getting
unnaturally long.

We focus in on this photo.

END OF PROLOGUE

ACT I

INT. SALONTRO - 11 YEARS LATER - DUSK

Rau trims Parsley's hair as he sits on a tanning bed.

RAU	PARSLEY
I love you. I love you lots.	I love you. I love you more.

RAU
What's the airspeed velocity of an
unladen dandelion seed?

PARSLEY
Thirty centimeters per second.

RAU
Square root of a boxwood?

PARSLEY
Please no more math, Mom.

Rau turns him to the mirror.

RAU
Behold! A Rootimentary graduate.
They got to pick you in dodgeball
before the Cherries now. How is the
ceremony planning with Ms. Red?

PARSLEY
Fruitful. Her partner treated the
class to extra CO2.

RAU
Tuyệt quá! Delightful. Who is he?
(Awesome!)

PARSLEY
Her name is Golden Delicious.

RAU
Oh. *She...* I see.

PARSLEY
She says Fig weddings are most fab-

RAU
Schools should stick to science.
Not fabulousness.

PARSLEY
A kid said love is like the bird
and the bee.

RAU

Nonsense. Birds go with birds. Bees
with bees. It's all rumors.

Parsley looks out at the glow of the nightclub next door.

PARSLEY

FigLeaf is buzzing.

RAU

And you need to buzz off to bed.
Your planter's made. Now lie in it.

Rau tucks a blanket inside a tanning bed. Parsley lies in it.

PARSLEY

Will the sun always be around?

"A NATURAL" LULLABY

RAU

NATURE...
NURTURED FROM THE LIGHT OF OUR SUN
IT'S NATURAL

PLANTING THEIR HOT FEET ON OUR
GROUND
THEY'RE NATURAL
BUT IT'S NOT AS WARM AS A MOM'S HUG

Rau hugs Parsley then she soon tickles him.

RAU

COMES NATURAL
WHAT'S NOT? THAT'D BE THE TICKLES!

A NATURAL... IS TRUE TO THEMSELVES
SON. YOU ARE A... NATURAL!

END OF "A NATURAL"

PARSLEY

I am a natural at lying... in bed.

RAU

You speak the truth.

PARSLEY

Mom. I wonder who'll be my moon...

RAU

Ngu ngon (Viet: "Sleep well"), my son.

EXT. SALONTRO - DUSK

The sun sets behind Salontro.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. MT. WOODWORK - DAWN

The sun rises behind a rural town of Mt. Woodwork, Woodwork.

ZOOM IN: Past the town center, through factories, stopping at a tree-like house beside a quiet pond: PYRUS'S HOUSE.

INT. PYRUS'S BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS

A messy teenager's room, posters and instruments everywhere. PYRUS (13) sleeps with BOMBUS (a big pet bee) on their face.

Once sunlight hits Bombus, they BUZZ like an alarm clock.

BOMBUS

Buzz! Buzz! Buzz! Buzz!

PYRUS

Buzz... off!

Pyrus throws Bombus into their hive-shaped bed.

INT. PYRUS'S BATHROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Pyrus stares at their acne-covered reflection in the mirror.

INT. PYRUS'S LIVING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

On the table are stacks of suspension letters from Terra Hill Conservatory, one is from Mom to Unty about summer babysitting.

EXT. PYRUS'S POND - MOMENTS LATER

Pyrus dives into the pond. The water echoes JUDGMENTAL VOICES.

WORLD

You will never amount to anything.

Pyrus sprints out of the water, sobbing. Bombus flies over and gently wipes a tear away with its antennae.

EXT. PYRUS'S HOUSE - SHORTLY AFTER

A rusted bus idles. Pyrus drags a suitcase through the door. They wave goodbye to Bombus in the window.

As the bus pulls away, Pyrus looks back and sees Bombus is already throwing a wild party in the bedroom. Pyrus scowls.

WOODWORK MAP

The country resembles the writer's home state of Michigan. A giant leaf (UP) connected to a tree trunk (LP). A line traces the bus route from Mt. Woodwork (UP) to Dirty City (LP).

EXT. DIRTY CITY - DAY

The bus drives past the welcome sign of Dirty City.

EXT. SALONTRO - DAY

A mail truck SMASHES into Salontro's mailbox, flattening it. The MAILPERSON (woodpulp) steps out with an envelope.

ANCHOR (TV)

Breaking news. Every transplant is
invasive under the newly ratified
Weed Out Act...

INT. SALONTRO - CONTINUOUS

Rau is glued to the TV. On screen, SAPP agents throw screaming transplants into armored vehicles.

ANCHOR (TV) (CONT'D)

By the end of summer, SAPP - Soil
and Plant Protection Agents - will
begin uprooting everyone without a
Green Card, including those with
pending applications.

On screen, an applicant's hands turn from blue to green.

RAU

Pending applications? I've been
waiting twelve years. This has got
to be an April Fool's Day joke.

THE TV CHYRON READS: "APRIL 2. NOT A JOKE." Rau groans.

The mailperson enters and slaps an envelope onto the counter:
SAPP - URGENT.

On screen, Rhizo Blomquist (50s) stands at a podium. THE TV
CHYRON READS: "SECRETARY OF GARDEN SECURITY RHIZO BLOMQUIST"

RAU (CONT'D)

That's the government plant that
never shook my hand...

On screen, a SUCCULENT REPORTER speaks with their mic.

REPORTER (TV)
Secretary Rhizo Blomquist, Woodwork
is home to many unadapted transplan-

RHIZO (TV)
Woodwork's government made clear
the statutory term is "invasive
species." Woodwork is no home to
invaders. That answers that. Now, I
ask: What's your paper?

REPORTER (TV)
Noticias de El Arbol.

RHIZO (TV)
That answers *where's* your paper.

SAPP agents surround the reporter.

REPORTER (TV)
Yo yo yo! I'm on a journalism visa!

RHIZO (TV)
Citizens are protected by the Leaf
of Rights. You are not. SAPP,
uproot this criminal.

REPORTER (TV)
Por favor, I got two kids born here-

Rau watches Parsley sweep the salon floor.

RHIZO (TV)
Too bad too sad. Those two orphans
can find loving homes away from law-
breaking invasive species. It's
time we uproot you criminals. With
no Green Card, you have no place on
our soil. You do not belong-

Rau SHUTS OFF the TV with a green remote. She looks at her
red hands, compared to the green remote.

PARSLEY
Need me to change the batteries?

Rau jumps, flinging the remote. It SHATTERS against the wall.

PARSLEY (CONT'D)
What's wrong, mom...?

RAU
Nothing! The... delivery plant just
forgot a package. A new remote!

MAILPERSON

I'm a veteran of New Leaf Delivery,
lady. I ain't ever forget packages.
What other place is named *Salontro*?

RAU

Play along. I don't want him to wor-

MAILPERSON

Worry not, cilantro. I'd play ball
with someone... who has a Green
Card. I ain't complicit in a crime
for a transplant. Toodeloo!

The mailperson storms out. Rau follows.

EXT. SALONTRO - MOMENTS LATER

The mailperson sits in the truck, moisturizing their wood-
pulp skin with a familiar bottle.

MAILPERSON (CONT'D)

I worry about ya. I'll miss them
scented moisturizers. Makes holding
them paper cutters worth it-

RAU

Wait- Is that my moisturizer? The
Paddy Kingdom shipment months ago-

The mailperson doesn't answer. They FLOOR it, clipping
another mailbox as they roar away.

Rau looks at her own crushed mailbox. She collapses.

BEGIN FLASHBACK

A 22-year-old Rau stands frozen before a wall of orange fire.
A motorbike lies mangled in the road. Smoke chokes the air as
the sirens of a distant ambulance scream.

END FLASHBACK

Rau shudders, forcing air back into her lungs. She stands,
gripping the SAPP envelope until her knuckles turn white.

RAU (CONT'D)

I'll be strong for you, brother.

INT. SALONTRO - SHORTLY AFTER

Parsley sweeps, his eyes drifting to the window. A bus hisses
to a stop outside FigLeaf. Pyrus steps off, looking lost. Rau
suddenly blocks Parsley's view.

RAU

The delivery messed up. I'll be right back.

Rau exits. Parsley is immediately back at the glass, watching the bus pull away to reveal Pyrus standing on the curb.

PARSLEY

This delivery looks perfect to me.

Malus saunters into the salon.

MALUS

Where's your mom?

PARSLEY

Out to get delivery.

MALUS

Strange. Usually she's just out to get *me*. I kid, I kid. Cow, Parsley.

PARSLEY

Chào. Why can't you ever sweeten your pronunciation, Malus?

MALUS

I'm a certain bi, not bilingual.

PYRUS (O.S.)

No malice.

MALUS

Yes, Pyrus! *My nibbling's in town.*

PYRUS (O.S.)

I want out of this dump! Take me to Cantaloupe Outlets, not this salon!

MALUS

You won't find me with those hipsters. How about Celery Mall?

PYRUS (O.S.)

You said we'd go where I wanted! You're more of an Apple Blossom than a Crabapple. Celery Mall only sells to old houseplants!

PARSLEY

Doing Celery Mall dirty? You'll fit right into Dirty City.

MALUS

Darn, Pear... Um. Tanning beds come in all sizes! There's gotta be one that matches ya body and fix ya up. Don't dig a hole for yourself.

PYRUS (O.S.)

Ain't dat what plants are supposed to do?! Let's go back to FigLeaf!

PARSLEY

I always wanna visit FigLeaf.

MALUS

You've got the spirit of a Fig, kid, but your mother would lose her freaking aldehyde if you go clubbin- It's a salon, Pyrus! You're making a mountain out of a molehill.

PYRUS (O.S.)

I make mountains out of anything!

"AMOUNT TO ANYTHING" SONG

Pyrus walks in with sunburns and green palms. Their entrance is like a teenage rocker with acne.

PYRUS (CONT'D)

MOUNTAINS OUTTA MOLE HILLS
NO REST. DISTRESSED. A MESS.
CARELESS.

I DELIVERED BRUISES AND I GOT INTO
TROUBLE AT SCHOOL.
SO, I'LL SPEND THIS SEASON WITH MY
ONE WEIRD UNTY.
I WON'T KNOW MALUS...

ALL BECAUSE REALLY
I WILL NEVER AMOUNT TO ANYTHING.
I WILL NEVER AMOUNT TO ANYTHING.
ANYTHING!

SUNBURNS. PIMPLES. ACNE. BIG DEAL.

I AIN'T ALWAYS THIN-SKINNED, BUT MY
THICK SKIN HAS NOT LOOKED REAL COOL
SO, I'LL WASTE MY SUMMER NEXT TO A
CILANTRO.
I CAN'T GIVE A MORSAL...

ALL BECAUSE IN LIFE,
I CARE NOT TO AMOUNT TO ANYTHING.

(MORE)

PYRUS (CONT'D)
I CARE NOT TO AMOUNT TO ANYTHING.
I DON'T CARE!
ANYTHING!

END OF "AMOUNT TO ANYTHING"

DIRTY CITY - TOWN SQUARE - DAY

Rau sits by the fountain, her hands trembling as she grips the SAPP envelope. In the shimmering water, she catches a glimpse of herself as a youthful migrant from the boat.

RAU
Everything. I'm losing everything.
She tears the envelope open. Her eyes race across the page.

RAU (CONT'D)
"Rau Ram... We are pleased to
inform you that your green card
application is now under review..."
Rau's shoulders drop. She lets out a breath.

RAU (CONT'D)
It only took twelve years.

MALUS (PRE-LAP)
Dat's a good age to start a serious
skincare routine, darling.
Rau jumps, tucking the letter away. She heads back with hope.

INT. SALONTRO - DAY

Pyrus and Malus are arguing nearby Parsley.

PYRUS
An artificial tan? I want the sun,
not a box!

MALUS
The Cherrys and Maples come here
all the time. Perfectly safe.

PARSLEY
Our beds are fully adjustable. We
can set the UV to whatever's
comfortable for a Pear.

MALUS
See? Parsley is level-headed.

PYRUS

I'll level with you, herb: ya can
spice up my skin, but you'll never
spice up my life.

(to Malus)

Don't look at me. I'll meet ya back
at FigLeaf.

MALUS

Ya seedlings enjoy yourselves!

Malus exits, blowing a kiss.

PYRUS

I ain't no seedling anymore, Malus!
Alright, lil herb. Do your thing.

Parsley leads Pyrus toward the rows of glowing tanning beds.

PARSLEY

High-pressure bed?

PYRUS

I ain't let sprouts pressure me.
The Roses at my school already give
me enough heat.

PARSLEY

Then stop comparing yourself to the
Roses. You Pear need to grow a
pair, a pair of thicker leaves.

PYRUS

Easy for you to say, poop-head. You
ain't even hit your growth spurt.

PARSLEY

I'm the number two in my class.
You're just... a number two.

PYRUS

Ha! Whatever, lil herb. Fine. Let's
face the heat.

Pyrus climbs into the tanning bed. It HUMS and GLOWS. When
they emerge, their sunburns are replaced by a radiant glow.

PYRUS (CONT'D)

I feel powerful. Dude... This ain't
natural.

PARSLEY

You Pears. Always dramatic. We both
need to grow up.

PYRUS

Ya ain't smooth. But ya alright.

Parsley pulls two fertilizer popsicles from a cooler and hands one to Pyrus.

PARSLEY

Fertilizer popicles?

PYRUS

Never gets old. Ya the stick.

PARSLEY

And ya ice cold... pop!

PARSLEY & PYRUS

We make a pretty great pair.

Rau enters, arms full of supplies. She stops dead.

RAU

Yes, mother and son make a great-
Who's this Pear?!

PYRUS

The name's Suc-my-pollen.

RAU

Suc-my-pollen?

PYRUS

Ew. I ain't sucking ya pollen, ya
nasty herb.

RAU

Well you look like Malus but green.

PARSLEY

Pears... Ugh. Mom, this is Pyrus.

PYRUS

Malus is my unty.

RAU

Reminds me: We need to catch up.

PYRUS

Ketchup is a tomato's hobby.

Rau stares down Pyrus.

EXT. FIGLEAF - DAY

Rau knocks on the nightclub door. Malus swings it open.

MALUS
So, ya met them?

RAU
Suc-my-pollen.

MALUS
Dat sounds like my Pyrus.

RAU
Why is this Pear here?

MALUS
Suspended from school. My sister
hopes I can "turn over a new leaf."

RAU
Are they here to suspend my
disbelief, too? Any other plans
besides bothering my son?

MALUS
Dat's actually the plan. You herbs
are good at math, right?

RAU
How dare you? We're GREAT at math!

MALUS
Let's cut a deal.

RAU
We aren't equals. There is no deal.

MALUS
Quit dividing us. If your son tutors
my nibling, I'll freeze rent.

RAU
Something's in the water...

Rau pauses, looking at her red hands, then at the nightclub
door. She gestures like she's about to agree.

INT. SALONTRO - LATE NOON

Pyrus pulls out a glass bottle, startling Parsley.

PYRUS
Time to test the water. What?
Ethanol's only fifteen percent...

PARSLEY
I can't drink that.

PYRUS

Why not?

PARSLEY

I'm not old enough.

PYRUS

"Not old enough"? I'm only two years older. This bottle cost 72 carbs. Can you count that high?

PARSLEY

I can count just fine. If you're so worried about the cost, I'll chip-

PYRUS

Nah, I'm saving every carb I can so I can finally prune my carbon-dated parents out of my life. Just a sip. You'll feel right at home.

Pyrus nudges the bottle toward him. Parsley reaches for it just as Rau enters. He shoves the bottle into a tanning bed.

RAU

Your unty is looking for you.

PYRUS

Real stubborn. See ya, lil herb!

Pyrus skips out. Rau glares after them.

RAU

Stay away from that problem fruit.

PARSLEY

Herbs and fruits can be friends. Woodwork is a melting pot!

RAU

Yeah, a pot where we'll melt!

PARSLEY

It's not my fault you settled here!

RAU

We haven't settled yet...

PARSLEY

You own this salon?

RAU

Malus owns Salontro. Not just a neighbor. They're our landlord.

PARSLEY

Then buy it from them.

RAU

I can't buy anything. Only native-born plants or Green Card holders can own property.

PARSLEY

Well, I was born here...

RAU

You're forgetting the age laws...

Rau steps toward the tanning bed where the bottle is hidden. Parsley pivots, blocking her path.

PARSLEY

What's the worry? You'll get your Green Card soon.

RAU

It's been twelve years...

PARSLEY

You're not getting uprooted. You've got my green hands to keep you rooted.

RAU

I... yeah. Well. At least you feel at home. That's what matters.

PARSLEY

I thought grades were what mattered-

RAU

Those too. Are you ready for your Rootimentary graduation speech?

PARSLEY

My classmates won't know what hit 'em!

RAU

Recite it for me?

PARSLEY

Germinations, Rootimentary class! My name is Parsley Ram...

The camera CIRCLES Parsley. The salon walls dissolve into...

INT. ROOTIMENTARY SCHOOL THEATRE - EVENING

...a sea of leaves and petals in a theatre repurposed for graduation with long buffet tables. Rau sits in the front table, beaming as Parsley in a blazer stands at the podium.

A slideshow of baby photos loops behind him.

PARSLEY

I'd like to start by thanking
mom... and Pyrus for being here.

Rau spins around to see Pyrus behind her, disheveled.

RAU

The Pear? What are you doing here?

PYRUS

Parsley listed me as his plus-two!

RAU

Well, you're blacklisted from me.

PYRUS

Woah. *Blacklisted*. Black looks
great on me! And green would look
real good on your hands!

Parsley falters.

RAU

Im lang. Sit down and be quiet.

PARSLEY

(Recovering)

The lunch-cherry once told us:
"Respect an apple a day to keep the
broccolis away."

PYRUS

Gotta hit the buffet before the
manure gets cold.

Pyrus zips to the buffet. They shovel steaming fertilizer into their mouth while a flowery CATERER stares in horror.

PARSLEY

We will miss Mossy Mondays...

Pyrus slumps back into the seat by Rau, slurping noisily.

PARSLEY (CONT'D)

You may not call me a friend, but I
am always here for you.

The projection shifts: A baby photo of Parsley and Rau is paired with a recent shot of Parsley and Pyrus at the salon.

AUDIENCE

Aww... Wait. Look at her hands.
She's a transplant? Red hands... No
Green Card? Invasive species...

The murmurs turns judgmental. Rau feels the room shrinking. She clenches her red hands and SLAMS them on the table.

RAU

Im lang- Shut up!

The room goes dead silent.

PYRUS

Yeah! I know this herb a month and he's a miracle. Who knew a troubled kid like me could speak with pride? He'd give the leaf off his back for anyone. He's the spirit of this place and he gets it from his mom!

The audience pauses, then erupts, tossing moss bouquets onto the stage. Pyrus storms the stage to high-five Parsley.

MS. RED, the apple teacher, approaches Rau.

RAU

Ms. Red... if you're giving me
"detention" for the outburst-

MS. RED

Detention? No. It is the *attention*
your son needed. Parsley is
brilliant, but he was lonely. You
have a lot to be proud of, Ms. Ram.

Rau watches Ms. Red walk away to join her partner, GOLDEN DELICIOUS. They link hands. Rau's pride turns into a scowl.

EXT. THEATRE - SHORTLY AFTER

Rau talks to Malus, who just arrived to pick up Pyrus.

RAU

Let's straighten your nibbling out.

MALUS

Dat's what us Figs love to hear.

Rau and Malus share a stiff handshake.

INT. BACKSTAGE - CONTINUOUS

Parsley and Pyrus hide behind a curtain.

PYRUS
Did you bring it?

Parsley pulls a bottle from his blazer and hands it to Pyrus.

PARSLEY
Our "friend."

Pyrus pops the cap.

PARSLEY (CONT'D)
Nothing to celebrate.

PYRUS
You're something, lil herb.

PARSLEY
You're everything, Pear.

Parsley takes a cautious sip. He immediately spits it out.

PARSLEY (CONT'D)
It's a *miracle* I got any taste.

PYRUS
Miracle's the name of the drink!
Well, looks like our friendship is
gonna go against the grain.

MALUS (O.S.)
Pyrus! Time to go!

PYRUS
I'm rooting for ya, Parsley.

Pyrus stows the bottle and runs off.

Parsley enters a dizzying state. The world transforms into a shimmering lake.

"TEST THE WATER" SONG

Parsley slowly breaks in his sea legs, dancing.

PARSLEY
(Repeating)
Glucose is clear. *Glucose clear.*

END OF "TEST THE WATER"

In reality, Parsley dances alone on stage. Rau and Malus stare, utterly baffled. Pyrus is holding back their laughter in the wings.

Rau sees her son not as Parsley, but as a ghost of...

BEGIN FLASHBACK

...her brother Cori Anh (15), fabulously dancing on a village stage. Rau (13) watches, amused.

CORI ANH

Chi gai (Viet: "Sister")! Join me!

YOUNG RAU

Can't, anh trai (Viet: "older brother"). Stage fright.

He pulls her up.

CORI ANH

Everything comes naturally to you, sis! Except bravery. You need to hunt them down.

RAU

You're unnatural, Cori Anh.

The cilantro siblings dance together.

END FLASHBACK

Rau is suddenly onstage, stopping Parsley's "dance."

MALUS

He's taking up theatre now?

RAU

He's acting so unnatural.

MALUS

Maybe he can also give Pyrus some acting lessons.

PARSLEY

I'm teaching?

RAU

Son. *Pear*... You've been promoted.

Rau links Parsley and Pyrus's hands.

END OF ACT I

ACT II**INT. SALONTRO - DAY**

Parsley and Pyrus sit amongst a wreckage of textbooks, notebooks, and half-eaten fertilizer snacks.

	PYRUS		PARSLEY
Tutor!		Student!	

PYRUS (CONT'D)
Suspended student.

PARSLEY
Suspension. Right. Chemistry or engineering? Take your pick.

PYRUS
How 'bout music? I know my suspended chords. Do fa sol! Re sol la! Mi la-

PARSLEY
Music theory's beyond my membrane.

PYRUS
Aight... But chemistry ain't. We're making a reaction, ain't we?

The kids lean in over a shared beaker.

MONTAGE:

- Parsley explains the periodic table while Pyrus uses a highlighter to draw thorns on the diagrams.
- In the main salon, Rau works double-time, scrubbing beds and mixing ointments alone. She hears the kids' laughing.
- Pyrus teaches Parsley how to vibe to a beat while Parsley tries to fix a broken tanning bed with a screwdriver.
- Rau watches the kids high-five over a solved math problem. Her expression is a mix of relief and growing isolation.
- The mailperson (woodpulp) enters with a lively package. They set it on the table where the kids are studying. A bee dissection diagram is on a board. The kids open up the box with Rau watching. Bombus flies out and makes a mess around the salon, before they zip towards us.

END MONTAGE

A yellow mane pokes through the door, followed by ALTON DANDY (40s), a Dandelion in a suit made of silk-pressed leaves.

Behind them, a tiny DRONE follows Dandy with a live feed.

DANDY

Sup, Dandy-lions! In the trenches
of Dirty City. Seeing the bright
Salontro. Potential for a SUNcondo.

Rau freezes, a spray in one hand and her red hands exposed.

RAU

Chào? This is a place of business,
not a... whatever that fly is.

DANDY

It's a cam-wasp, herb. Name's Alton
Dandy, All Dandy Properties.
(Inhaling the air)
Oof. Smells like... Paddy-ness?

RAU

My Bee's Knees ointment? It heals—

DANDY

Don't need a struggle story, herb.
Though people love those.

They taps a button on his tablet. A contract projects on it.

ALTON DANDY

Fifty thousand carbs for the deed.
You move out, I move in, turn this
mud-pit into Dandelion-tro.

Parsley and Pyrus peak out from the back.

RAU

Move out? This is my family's root!

DANDY

Look. The Weed Out Act is here. You
have no Green Card. You're about to
get mowed. Take the cash. Go back
to wherever you sprouted from.

RAU

I'm under review! I have rights!

DANDY

Rights are for homeowners, herb.
This may be an exit strategy before
SAPP give you a one-way ticket.

Bombus, sensing Rau's distress, ZIPS toward the drone. They
SMACK into the camera, sending the drone into a tailspin.

DANDY (CONT'D)

Don't hurt my tax write-off!

The drone crashes into a vat of Bee's Knees ointment, EXPLODING honey goo that coats Dandy's expensive suit. They stop, touch their face where the goo landed.

DANDY (CONT'D)

My leaves! I'm soaked in... in...
Wait. This... feels amazing. Did
you get that?! The "Dandy Glow!"
This is a goldmine.

RAU

Get out of my salon, you weed!

DANDY

This isn't over! I'll buy this
whole block! As CEO, I'll buy the
CO2 you breathe!

They storm out. The drone trails a sticky path of yellow ointment behind them.

PARSLEY

Mom? Are we... in trouble?

Rau looks at her red hands, then at the door.

RAU

We're in business. It needs trouble-

INT. DEPARTMENT OF GARDEN SECURITY HEADQUARTERS

Rhizo scrolls their feed on a massive monitor. They sigh at the trending hashtags: #Cilantro #Dandelion #DirtyCity

They tap the monitor. The video of Rau standing in her salon pauses. Biometric tech immediately flags her face.

CHYRON: RAU RAM. LAST KNOWN LOCATION: DIRTY CITY.

Rhizo pulls up her case file. They smile grimly.

RHIZO

Found you.

EXT. PINERY PARK - DAY

A SAPP truck rumbles toward a bustling flea market. Nearby, Pyrus draws a moustache on a poster of MAYOR CANNA BLOMQUIST, Rhizo's twin. Parsley watches. Bombus crawls on the poster.

PYRUS

Watcha think, Bombus?

Bombus places their antennas on Canna.

PYRUS (CONT'D)

Ya right. They need antennas.

Pyrus draws antennas.

PARSLEY

You're defacing a family friend.

PYRUS

Ya pals with the freakin' mayor?!

Rau enters, lugging boxes of "Bee's Knees."

RAU

Canna's never looked better. Now
stop the civil disobedience and
help your mother.

Parsley and Pyrus help carry some boxes.

INT. FLEA MARKET - CONTINUOUS

They enter a market at the pine-inspired park. They walk by a pen full of bunny-esque FLEAS. Those fleas are hopping.

PARSLEY

Aww... Can we get a flea, mom?

RAU

What did I say about pets?

PARSLEY

Pets will eat our customers, I
know... But, Bombus eats honey.

PYRUS

(Making a monstrous face)
For now! Buzz!

They reach a booth labeled SALONTRO. CANNA BLOMQUIST (50s) is already there, waiting. They pat Bombus.

CANNA

Germinations! Business looks...
fruitful, Rau.

RAU

The ointment is making a killing.
You here for your free massage?

CANNA

Always. Who's the Pear?

CANNA (CONT'D)

Thanks to your killer bee mascot.
The star of the show!

PYRUS

Pyrus. I'm guessing you're spend
her taxes on concert tickets,
vacations. I aspire to be you!

CANNA

Are cilantro adopting radical Pears-

A SAPP truck screeches to a halt at the entrance.

PYRUS

(like saying the "police")
It's the *broccolis*!

CANNA (O.S.)

Our broccolis is underfunded. This
is a federal department led by my
twin, Rhizo Blomquist, Woodwork's
Secretary of Garden Security. The
Soil and Plant Protection Agency.

Rhizo and armored SAPP AGENTS storm the market.

RHIZO

SAPP. The best place to find
immigrant transplants is at a flea
market. This one's hopping full of
them! Now hop to it!

Agents begin kicking over stands and detaining transplants
with non-green hands. Rau dives under her table.

SAPP AGENTS

Uproot! Uproot! Uproot!

Canna goes to the middle of the crowd. They panic even more.

CANNA

Have no fear, your mayor is here!

Rhizo looms over the booth.

RHIZO

Where are your parents, kid?

PARSLEY

On what jurisdiction?

RHIZO

I'm just messing with you, herb!
You're the Seedling Protective
Services' problem.

Rhizo moves on. Parsley pulls Rau's polaroid camera from a box and begins SNAPPING PHOTOS of the brutality.

Canna ducks under the table with Rau.

RAU

Canna! Hiding from your
constituents?

CANNA

They are no constituent.

"GOVERNMENT PLANT" SONG

CANNA (CONT'D)

MY TWIN IS A GOVERNMENT PLANT.

RAU

WAIT. YOU'RE A GOVERNMENT PLANT!

Canna approaches a hippie BUSKER with mics, amps, and lutes.

CANNA

You got a busking permit?

BUSKER

We need a permit for breathing too?

CANNA

Hand the mic for a musical number
and I'll let you off the hook.

BUSKER

Steal away, bureaucracy.

Canna takes over a mic. They kiss it.

CANNA

ARE YOU POWER HUNGRY?

RHIZO

I FIND YOUR QUESTION FUNNY

CANNA

WHAT ARE YOU RUNNING?

RHIZO

EVERYTHING-

CANNA
INTO THE GROUND

RHIZO & CANNA
CAUSE WE'RE GOVERNMENT PLANTS
ONLY HERE TO DANCE
AROUND THE CRAZIES
UNDER BUREAUCRACY

RHIZO
YOU FOUND SANCTUARY?

CANNA
THE MOST WELCOMING CITY!

RHIZO
IT'S NOT WITH TRANSPLANTS

CANNA
THEIR PRESENCE

RHIZO
WILL END OUR GARDEN!

CANNA
Recall, mom's the first transplant
to be elected to public office. How
could you betray our roots?

RHIZO
I'm respecting the Woodwork roots.

CANNA
I'm gonna tell mom!

RHIZO & CANNA
YOU GOVERNMENT PLANT.

END OF "GOVERNMENT PLANT"

Pyrus kicks open a pen of giant fleas. They pummel SAPP
agents with mighty hops.

BOMBUS
Buzz! Buzz! Buzz! Buzz! Buzz! Buzz!

Bombus unlocks the tranplants' handcuffs with their stinger.

SAPP AGENTS
Flee! Flee! Fleeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeee!

The agents retreat to their truck. Rhizo flips over the
Salontro table, exposing a shaking Rau.

RHIZO

My favorite transplant. I know
where the salon lies. You can't
hide, Rau. Chào.

Rhizo boards the truck. It roars away. Canna helps Rau up.
Parsley hands Rau the photos.

PARSLEY

We have to show the world.

RAU

I should hide the world from you.

PARSLEY

They need to see it! We have to
fight back.

CANNA

If Rhizo has a force then...

Rhizo points at Rau.

INT. CITY HALL - DAY

Canna stands at a podium before a swarm of REPORTERS. Rau
stands behind them with other transplants.

CANNA

...we must assemble our Transplant
Task Force, the hard-working roots
of Dirty City's economy. To foster
community, I'm providing members
our database of every refugee
transplant in this city. Community
is our best defense.

Canna passes out a stack of booklets.

INT. DEPARTMENT OF GARDEN SECURITY HEADQUARTERS - CONTINUOUS

Rhizo leans into a monitor, seeing Canna hands Rau a booklet.

RHIZO

A database of all invasives in town-
You just did my job for me, twin...

On screen, a red liquid SPLASHES Rau's face. Protestors JEER.

DIRTY CITY CITIZEN (TV)

Go home to your garden, invasive
species!

Rhizo laughs as the feed dissolves into chaos.

INT. SALONTRO - NIGHT

Rau enters, wiping dried red from her face. Parsley pops out of a tanning bed. His smile vanishes. He hugs her tight.

PARSLEY

Me (Viet: "Mom")?! You're red as your leaves!

RAU

My leaves have been a problem since my parents were pushing up daisies.

PARSLEY

Will they ever come back to help?

RAU

No... But we have the Mayor. Tomorrow, they and I are being interviewed right here. Let's make this salon worthy of royalty.

Parsley swiftly cleans the hair cut section of the salon.

JUMP CUT TO:

INT. SALONTRO - DAY

The CAMERA CREW sets up. Rau prepares to trim Canna's petals once the cameraperson cues them.

CANNA

Ready for the spotlight?

RAU

So long as it involves no red dye.

THROUGH THE CAMERA:

REPORTER

We're live with Mayor Blomquist and a member of the Transplants Task Force... What is happening, Mayor?

CANNA

Just getting a trim from my favorite cilantro. Transplants are the back-petals of this nation.

REPORTER

And you won't backpedal on that?

CANNA

Rau, bring forward your culture.

RAU

I don't know what more to add to
the Woodworkan ecosystem.

CANNA

I'll speak for her. The herbs are
something special. One time, I was
on a vacay in Paddy Kingdom. Lovely
weather. Even more lovelier plants.
Believe me when I say those *laksa*
leaves will leave you enlightened.

RAU

Laksa leaves?!

Rau over trims Canna's hair.

CANNA

Ow! Trimming too close.

RAU

Plantist slurs are unwelcomed here.

CANNA

It's what you herbs call
yourselves, *laksa* woman!

RAU

It's not your word to say, *Wildflow-*

CANNA

Wildflower?!

REPORTER

Let's backpedal-...

CANNA

You're going too far, *laksa*!

RAU

Wildflower!

Rau and Canna erupt into a physical scuffle, spraying each
other with salon products as the reporter tries to intervene.

REPORTER

This is WoodTV News. A historic
partnership turned into...

INT. BUS - DAY

Rau sits amongst tired PLANTS draped in glitter and flags
returning from a pride parade. The bus blares the radio.

REPORTER (RADIO) (CONT'D)
...a historic disaster where a
transplant attacked our mayor...

Rau groans. She looks at a napping plant in the next seat,
then discreetly slides their rainbow sash off their shoulder.

INT. SALONTRO - MOMENTS LATER

Parsley and Pyrus wobbles in, decked in rainbow gear.

PYRUS
That parade was a vibe!

PARSLEY
I was just... so thirsty. I'm glad
we found some liquid.

PYRUS
But it ain't water.

PARSLEY
I can handle Miracle just fine.

Parsley trips, knocking over the sculpture of Cori Anh.

PYRUS
You're manhandling Miracle alright.

A bus marked "DIRTY CITY PRIDE" stops nearby.

PYRUS (CONT'D)
You probably don't wanna be
manhandled by your mama!

PARSLEY
Quick. Throw the rainbow away. She
doesn't like Figs!

PYRUS
But... I'm a f- Huh.

Pyrus sees the trash bin where Parsley is stuffing his gear.
They turn and exit through the back, looking betrayed.

Rau enters, with a fake smile and the stolen rainbow sash.

RAU
It's "Pride" month, Parsley. Which
means today, we aren't just a
salon. We're an *ally*.

PARSLEY
So we're supporting Pyrus and Malus-

RAU

We support *money*. Now let's rainbow-
Dua tiên đây!
(*Give us money!*)

MONTAGE:

- Parsley flips the sign to OPEN. A crowd of multicolor Fig patrons rushes in.
- Rau dabs Bee's Knees ointment onto a customer's leaves. She whispers: "Thirty-one percent off with a rainbow selfie!"
- Rau takes a 20-carbs price tag, crosses it out, and writes 45 carbs in rainbow glitter ink.
- Parsley tries to talk to a group of kids about history. Rau pushes a branded "Gay Apparel" shirt into their hands.
- Rau stands by the register, her hands moving like a blur as she stacks piles of money.

END MONTAGE

INT. SALONTRO - NIGHT

The salon is empty. Rau locks the door. The fake smile stops. She rips off the sash, tossing it into a glittery trash bin. She counts a massive stack of bills.

RAU

Unnatural... but profitable.

PARSLEY

Mom, the kids today... they were
just like Pyrus. They weren't
"unnatural." They were happy.

Rau pounds the counter.

RAU

Happy? They were distracted. Like
your uncle.

She points to the sculpture of Cori Anh, still knocked over.

START FLASHBACK

Rau revisits the scene of her brother's motorbike accident.

RAU (V.O.)

His love of rainbows led to booze
then to his doom. He's the light of
our lives that went dark too soon.

END FLASHBACK

She sets Cori Anh upright.

RAU
He chose the "rainbow", son.

She grabs the money and stuffs it into a drawer.

PARSLEY
With the extra income, I do need a
vacation away from the rainbow...
Cantaloupe Outlets. With Pyrus.

RAU
That trashy shopping center?
Absolutely not. It's full of
Broccolis and bad influences.

PARSLEY
We just want to see *Popcorn!*

RAU
Oh no. That movie is for adults.
Heat and corn, not a pretty sight!

PARSLEY
There's no kernel of truth in that.

Rau hands money to Parsley.

RAU
Here's ten carbs for *VeggieWhales-*

PARSLEY
You are so corny-

RAU
No corn! Let me know what Pyrus
thinks of the killer kale pod. Now
get yourself ready as a plum.

Rau hands a food container and a watering can to Parsley.
Parsley jumps into a tanning bed.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. CANTALOUPE OUTLETS - DAY

Parsley sits inside the photo booth. Pyrus joins him.

"PHOTOSYNTHESIS" SONG

PARSLEY
GET YOUR BUTT IN THE PHOTO BOOTH.
WE'RE GONNA TAKE A LITTLE BREATHER.

PYRUS
BREATHE IN, BREATHE OUT.

Pyrus drinks from a watering can.

PARSLEY
MAKE SURE THAT YOU STAY HYDRATED.
WE'RE GONNA DRINK LOTS OF WATER.

PYRUS
H 2 O.

PARSLEY
NOW GET YOURSELF SITUATED.
WE'RE GONNA MAKE TONS OF SUGAR.

PYRUS
SWEET MEMORIES.

PARSLEY
SIX CARBON DIOXIDE!

PYRUS
AND PLUS...
SIX WATER MOLECULES.

PARSLEY & PYRUS
PUT IT UNDER LIGHT.

PARSLEY	PYRUS
C 6	SUGAR,
H 12 (TWELVE)	SUGAR,
O 6...	SUGAR,
PLUS 6 O 2.	AND STARCH.
GLUCOSE,	6 CARBON
GLUCOSE,	12 HYDROGEN
GLUCOSE,	6 OXYGEN...
AND STARCH.	PLUS 6 OXYGEN MOLECULES.
THIS IS PHOTOSYNTHESIS.	
PHOTOSYNTHESIS.	CARBOHYDRATE!

Parsley pulls many ingredients.

PYRUS (CONT'D)
YOU'RE OVERREACTING.

PARSLEY
I WANNA GOOD PRODUCT.

PYRUS
YOU'LL GET BYPRODUCTS.

Parsley and Pyrus dance the sweetest of dances.

PARSLEY <i>BI...?</i> SUGAR, SUGAR, SUGAR, AND STARCH. 6 CARBON 12 HYDROGEN 6 OXYGEN... PLUS 6 OXYGEN MOLECULES. CARBOHYDRATE!	PYRUS (CONT'D) SUGAR RUSH! C 6 H 12 (TWELVE) O 6... PLUS 6 O 2. YOUR CELLULOSE. YOUR CELLULOSE. WE WRITE: PHOTOSYNTHESIS. PHOTOSYNTHESIS.
--	--

The space displays the equation: $6CO_2 + 6H_2O \rightarrow C_6H_{12}O_6 + 6O_2$.

PARSLEY & PYRUS

C 6
 H 12 (TWELVE)
 O 6...
 PLUS 6 O 2.

 6 CARBON
 12 HYDROGEN
 6 OXYGEN
 PLUS 6 OXYGEN MOLECULES.

 PHOTOSYNTHESIS.
 PHOTOSYNTHESIS.
 PHOTO!

The booth flashes and prints a literal herb and pear photo.
Parsley and Pyrus exit the booth.

END OF "PHOTOSYNTHESIS"

Rhizo's face fills every TV monitor in the mall food court.

RHIZO (TV)

This is your Secretary of Garden
 Security reminding you sugar and
 water are a privilege, not a right.

PYRUS

We needed dat breather. Redoing the
 photo scene in Rotten Tomatoes was
 fun. PG-12, little herb.

PARSLEY & PYRUS

Rotten Tomatoes is the all-time
greatest movie!

PYRUS

It deserves to win the Raspberries.

PARSLEY

I'd certify that it was *freshhhh*.

PYRUS

But the ending... kids' fruits of
labor end up diced tomatoes.

PARSLEY

Can I have another sip of Miracle?

Pyrus tucks the hidden bottle deeper into their hoodie.

PYRUS

Nope. It was hard enough hiding it
in the theatre. Quit the sour face,
sour grapes. No whining about wine
either. You don't need Miracle-

RAU (PRE-LAP)

I need a miracle!

INT. SALONTRO - DAY

Rau stares at a TV, sifting through a stack of SAPP letters.

REPORTER (TV)

President Pumpkin Eater has
outlined farm orders to ramp up
uprootings on the Woodwork coast...

RHIZO (O.S.)

Miraculous, isn't it?

Rau flinches and flings the remote again. Rhizo catches it.

RHIZO (CONT'D)

I won't uproot you, Ram. Why would
I do that to someone who's kept me
grounded. You're my miracle.

RAU

Not afraid I hurt you like your twi-

RHIZO

Hurting Canna is always bonus
points in my book.

RAU

Do you want an appointment, Rhizo?
A free massage, like the mayor?

RHIZO

Unlike the mayor, I have important
things to do. Like this.

"THE OTHER SIDE" SONG

RHIZO (CONT'D)

I'M HERE TO AWARD YOU...
YOUR GREEN CARD.

Rhizo pulls a crisp green card from his pocket. Rau stares.
Hope fights terror in her eyes.

RAU

IS IT GREEN ON THE OTHER SIDE?

RHIZO

IT IS.
WHOSE SIDE ARE YOU ON?

RAU

WHAT SIDES?

RHIZO

THE TRANSPLANTS OR THE OTHERS.
GIVE UP THE TRANSPLANTS
SPECIFICALLY YOUR LIST OF THEM

RAU

I CAN'T BETRAY MY COMMUNITY.

RHIZO

THIS COMMUNITY WON'T WELCOME YOU
IF YOU STRAY

RHIZO (CONT'D)

You can't stay

CORI ANH (PRE-LAP)

You can't stay!

RAU'S MIND / INT. SALONTRO - CONTINUOUS - INTERCUT

On a motorbike, Cori Anh drives a tearful Rau through a war-torn landscape. He stops in a calm clearing.

CORI ANH

Smile when you get your green card,
chi gai.

Rau forces a smile and hands the task force booklet to Rhizo.
Rhizo hands Rau her green card. They clip the corner of the
green card to the red fingerprint on her case file.

Rau's hand magically mixes colors. The effects turn into Cori Anh's red hands touching Rau's hands. The red washes away from Rau, leaving a white canvas.

CORI ANH (CONT'D)
Sister. You're on the other side.

Cori Anh waves goodbye, dissolving into a red and green fog. Rau waves back with her white hands. They turn green.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. SALONTRO - CONTINUOUS

Rau's stares at her hands. They are undeniably green.

RHIZO
RAU RAM. YOU'RE A WOODWORKAN.

Rau kneels and digs her fingers into the dirt floor, feeling the soil's pulse for the first time as a citizen.

END OF "THE OTHER SIDE"

EXT. CANTALOUPE OUTLETS - DAY

Parsley and Pyrus run into a mannequin in a vibrant CROP TOP amongst a bunch of clothes rack.

PYRUS
This top would be perfect for our
summer solstice rave!

PARSLEY
What's a rave?

PYRUS
A party where everyone smells like
asparagus and bass shakes ya roots.

PARSLEY
I wanna go! But Malus will be there-

PYRUS
Nope. The summer solstice is their
annual camping trip.

PARSLEY
Oh, right. Mom's actually invited
this year. She's going. So I can go-

PYRUS
Lemme lay down some *ground rules*.

PARSLEY

"Ground rules" sounds like a song!

PYRUS

No time.

RAU (PRE-LAP)

No time...

DIRTY CITY - VARIOUS LOCATIONS - DAY

Rau dives into the soil for the first time, tunneling at lightning speeds. She pops up on a busy corner, her vibrant green hands held high.

RAU

...to tell the world, I got my
Green Card!

DIRTY CITY CITIZENS

The cilantro's now a wild-herb.

Rau dives and resurfaces blocks away, basking in the light.

RAU

Hi, sun! I got to tell my real son!

She dives in dirt, racing towards Cantaloupe Outlets.

EXT. CANTALOUPE OUTLETS - CONTINUOUS

PYRUS

No kids allowed. Bet ya can't
handle an all-nighter.

PARSLEY

It's the summer solstice! The
night's only a few hours. I bet I
look better in the moonlight.

PYRUS

Lil herb. Ain't no way ya top me!

"CROP TOP" SONG

Pyrus puts on a crop top from a clothing rack.

PYRUS (CONT'D)

NOW, IT'S YA TURN.
PICK A PATTERN.

Parsley picks up a t-shirt, but Pyrus nabs and tosses it.

PYRUS (CONT'D)

NO NO. RETURN!

(MORE)

PYRUS (CONT'D)
THE CREAM OF THE CROP DAT IS
FASHION.
NO SHIRT CAN EVER TOP THIS!

Parsley reads the crop top tag.

PARSLEY
A CROP TOP...?

PYRUS
WHERE TO FIND ONE DAT FITS?
WEAR ONE DAT SUITS YA PERSONALITY.

Pyrus plays with their belly then puts a crop top on Parsley.

PARSLEY
THERE GOES YOUR BELLY.

PYRUS
YA CANNOT BE STOPPED WHEN YA PUT
YOURSELF IN THIS CROP TOP!

PARSLEY
IT FEELS SO WARM YET SO COOL...

PYRUS
IT CUTS TO YA HEART'S BOTTOM.
IT HAS YA FEELING ON TOP!
YA CANNOT BE STOPPED WHEN YOU'RE
DANCING IN ROCKING CROP TOPS!

PARSLEY
I TOP YOURS!

PYRUS
YA BOTTOM FEEDER!

PARSLEY
I'M ON TOP!

PYRUS (CONT'D)
I'LL CROP YOU!

Pyrus chases Parsley around the mannequin. The mannequin's reflection mirrors Parsley and his future queer self.

PYRUS (CONT'D)
YOU'RE THE TOP OF THE CROP TO TOP
IT ALL OFF!

PARSLEY
NO ONE PULLS THEM OFF LIKE ME...

Parsley and Pyrus pose in their crop tops by the mannequin.

PARSLEY & PYRUS
CROP TOP!

END OF "CROP TOP"

Rau bursts into the clothing rack display, her face glowing green with pride, ready to share her news.

RAU

Son... I-

Her eyes land on his crop top. Pure fury replaces her smile.

BEGIN FLASHBACK AND MONTAGE

- Cori Anh (24), in crop tops, dancing in a nightclub.
- The dance blurs. He stumbles, with a bottle of Miracle.
- A rainy night in Paddy Kingdom. The motorbike breaks apart.
- Rau (22) screaming in the mud, holding her brother's lifeless red hand as the rain washes away the glitter from his face.

END FLASHBACK AND MONTAGE

RAU (CONT'D)

I'm gonna crop your top off!

PARSLEY

Me (Viet: "Mom")?!

RAU

The plants here are watching an herb make a scene. Pull it off now!

PYRUS

You're the one making a scene, Rau. Parsley, ya pulling off that crop top. His plot's going places!

RAU

Im lang, đò vô hoc (Viet: "Shut up, you uneducated person")!

PYRUS

Watcha mom say? Ain't heard this.

PARSLEY

Me... (Viet: "Mom") You're the ignorant one. Con đĩ ("Insult")!

PYRUS

Look at ya foaming at ya stomata mouth! Lil herb. Whatever it is. I can't believe ya said it. Ya son of-

Rau SLAPS Parsley across the face. Silence falls over the clothing racks. Rau drags him away, heartbroken.

PYRUS (CONT'D)
A jerk! Rooting for ya, Parsley!

PARSLEY
Mom. As you've said: "*A natural is true to themselves.*"

RAU
A natural?! You're not true to yourself. What you and Pyrus are doing... It is unnatural!

"SOILED (THE FAMILY NAME)" SONG

RAU (CONT'D)
ARE YOU OUT OF YOUR ALDEHYDE?
WHY CAN'T YA LEAVE THE PUBLIC'S EYE?
WILL YOU LEARN YOU'RE NEVER RIGHT?
DON'T YOU EVER EVER LIE!

PARSLEY
CAN I LIVE WITHOUT HAVING TO HIDE?
MAY I MAKE MY BED WHERE I DECIDE?
DO I HAVE ANY SORT OF RIGHTS?
TIL THEN, I WILL ALWAYS LIE!

RAU
I won't let you lie six inches
under like your uncle!

YOU ARE GROUNDED FOR LIFE!

TOY WITH ME
AND I WILL FEED YOU TO PESTS.
YOU BURY OUR KIN IN SHAME,
AND YOU WILL MEET OUR ANCESTORS IN
DEATH!

SOIL OUR NAME
AND I WILL RAIN HELLFIRE!
YOU HAVE NO ONE ELSE TO BLAME.

ARE YOU LISTENING, PARSLEY RAM?
I'M SO TIRED...

PARSLEY
If you did not want me to conform
to the ecosystem, why give me a
Workworkan name like "Parsley?!"

Me, *soil the family name...*
(MORE)

PARSLEY (CONT'D)
Who was it that didn't give me a
foreign name like you, Rau?!

RAU
Anh thanh niên (Viet: "Young man"),
"gay."

PARSLEY
Young men cannot stay grounded!
Thanks for the validation. I am no
longer a seedling. Gay. Happy. I
don't want it any other way.

RAU
YOU ARE A CRIME.
DON'T MAKE ME CRY.

PARSLEY (CONT'D)
I'M AT MY PRIME.
I FEEL LIKE DY-

RAU (CONT'D)
YOU SOILED...

PARSLEY	PYRUS
IN THE NAME OF FAMILY, I GAVE	IN THE NAME OF FAMILY, YOU
YOUR LIFE SOIL!	GAVE OUR LIVES SOIL!

Parsley hides in the photo booth.

END OF "SOILED (THE FAMILY NAME)"

RAU
We're soiled inside...

PYRUS
Get outta his personal space, ya
invasive species-

RAU
You've got some xylems calling me
that! Pyrus... Who taught you to
address me this way?

PYRUS
Malus says ya are who ya are.

Pyrus turns and exits, leaving Rau standing alone.

MATCH CUT TO:

CAREX DUNE - SUMMER SOLSTICE - DAY

Rau, now lugging heavy camping gear, exhaustedly trails Malus
up a steep sand dune. The sun is high and hot.

RAU
Malus. Tell me... who am I?

MALUS

Ya a Woodworkan. Always knew ya be.
But ya certainly weren't a scout!

RAU

Were you?

MALUS

Much more.

They reach the crest of the dune. A campground is set up. A pack of old plants sit around a fire pit: PADDY WAR VETERANS.

MALUS (CONT'D)

Welcome to my annual summer
solstice retreat!

VETS

Chào!

MALUS

Rau's son tutors my nibbling! And
she just got her Green Card!

VET

A Paddish cilantro with Woodwork
citizenship. You love to see it.

RAU

Germinations... veterans? This is a
side of you I've not seen.

MALUS

I ain't just green on the other
side. I was red and a little orange-

RAU

What were you doing on red's land?

MALUS

It's a long story.

RAU

I've got the whole summer solstice.

Malus sits Rau down. They revisit their childhood.

EXT. DIRTY CITY - LONG AGO

MALUS (V.O.)

A tree's lifetime ago, I was born
on the winter solstice. The
shortest day. Eventually, also the
day my parents kicked me out.

Young Malus lies shivering on the concrete. MINNEOLA ORANGE finds them, wrapping them in an orange coat.

MALUS (V.O.)
Minneola Orange found me, sheltered
me in FigLeaf. Then the Paddy War
came, and things turned Orange.

PADDY KINGDOM - VARIOUS LOCATIONS - 30 YEARS AGO - DAY

A helicopter touches down in a lush field. 20-year-old Malus steps out with a polaroid camera and follows Agent Orange.

RAU (V.O.)
You... fought in the Paddy War?

MALUS (V.O.)
Figs don't fight. Figs made peace.

AGENT ORANGE
We come in peace, not slices!

Malus notices 6-year-old RAU sketching in the dirt.

YOUNG MALUS
May I see?

Rau shows her drawing: a kind Apple and a terrifying Orange.

YOUNG MALUS (CONT'D)
Traditional photosynthesis is slow.
Want to see it happen instantly?

MALUS (V.O.)
...or so I thought we made peace.

Malus takes a selfie with Rau. The photo ejects. FLASH!

EXT. RAU'S VILLAGE - 5 YEARS LATER - DAY

The polaroid photo burns in a pile of ash. The village is screaming. Agent Orange walks through the smoke with a torch. Malus trails behind, looking on distraught and betrayed.

AGENT ORANGE
We've come for your pieces!

MALUS (V.O.)
Orange thought if they came home a
war hero, all Figs would be heroes.
They didn't care at what cost.

YOUNG MALUS
What are you doing?!

AGENT ORANGE
Winning this war, you?!

YOUNG MALUS
Shooting film. And your war crimes!

Malus snaps a photo of Agent Orange. The flash blinds them, preventing them from harming more villagers. They grapple for the camera. It flies from Malus's hands, landing elsewhere.

11-year-old Rau crawls through wreckage and finds the camera. She finds Fig emblems and tags. She trusts no Figs since.

MALUS
Orange peeled their life away to
save mine...

In a clearing, Malus cradles a dying, peeled Agent Orange.

AGENT ORANGE
Agent Crabapple... take care of
FigLeaf for me.

INT. SUMMER SOLSTICE RETREAT - DUSK

Rau pulls away. Malus gets the Salontro deed from a bag.

RAU
I saw those dog tags. I thought
your kind loved the fire.

MALUS
I've spent decades putting it out.

RAU
Please no. I've been saving up.

MALUS
Salontro is on the house.

RAU
Freeing me doesn't have to be free.

MALUS
This ain't free. It's what I owe
you herbs. What we owe your people.

INT. SALONTRO - SAME TIME

"FERTILE" SONG

A tanning bed holds a soiled blanket, where Parsley pops out.

PARSLEY

THE WORLD REVOLVES AROUND MORE THAN
YOUR SON
WHY CAN'T YOU SEE THAT?
AN HERB WHO NEEDS THEIR PLANT
FRIENDS
PLANET, TOPPED OFF WITH CROPS AND
VEGETABLES
YOU DON'T SEE MY PRODUCE-
IT IS TRULY FUTILE

IN THIS "SOILED" FAMILY,
I AM MEANT TO GET DIRTY, REAL DIRTY
HOW ELSE WILL I EVER BEAR FRUIT?
I AM FERTILE
VOLATILE!

FIGLEAF WOULD NEVER DEFER MY SMILE
A CLEAR COMMUNITY WHO WOULD ACCEPT
ME AND ALL...
THE WHILE MOM KILLS ME TO PUT IT
MILDLY
THIS WILL BE MY TRIAL
I'M WILDER THAN A CHILD

AM I TO SNEAK OUT?
MY MAMA...
THIS WILL NOT HELP ME COME CLEAN,
WITHOUT MEANS
MY DROP WILL NOT BE SO FRUITFUL

PYRUS (O.S.)

IT AIN'T FUTILE!

Parsley looks out the window and sees Pyrus outside.

PYRUS (CONT'D)

LET'S GET WILD!

PARSLEY

RECONCILE!

PYRUS (CONT'D)

YOU BELONG IN AN OPEN FIELD

PARSLEY

I LONG FOR WHAT'S QUEER AND
ANYWHERE SO SURREAL

Pyrus tosses a crop top to Parsley.

PYRUS

WEAR THIS BEFORE IT GOES OUTTA STYLE
YOU HAVE MADE ME REALIZE: IN LIFE,
IT IS NEVER FUTILE...

PARSLEY
I AM FERTILE!

END OF "FERTILE"

Parsley climbs out of the window.

INT. FIGLEAF NIGHTCLUB - NIGHT

Parsley lands by Pyrus in the rave.

DJ CAULIFLOWER
We got a Cilantro in da yard!

PARSLEY
And we got a Cauliflower on guard?

DJ CAULIFLOWER
Not just a Cauliflower. *The*. DJ...

DJ CAULIFLOWER (30s), wearing a kale-leaf jacket and neon headphones, aims a mic at the crowd like a scepter.

"DIRT ON YOU" SONG

PARSLEY
Holy sneezeworts. It's DJ...

DJ CAULIFLOWER
Wadaya, houseplants?! You know who
I am, Dirty City! We gotta be weed
in dis cement. Me- Imma godsend!

WE DA BEST...

PYRUS
WE ARE BEST...

DJ CAULIFLOWER
WE DA BEST...

PARSLEY & PYRUS
WE ARE BEST FRIENDS!

DJ CAULIFLOWER (CONT'D)
WE DA BEST HOUSEPLANTS!

PARSLEY
IT'S DJ...?

PYRUS
IT'S DJ...

DJ CAULIFLOWER
DJ CAULIFLOWERRRR!

PYRUS
I love this song!

PARSLEY

Which one? DJ Cauliflower starts
every song like-

PYRUS

Don't make me squash ya into pesto.
LET'S GET DIRTY!
LET'S GET DIRTY, PARSLEY?

PARSLEY

YOU GET DIRTY, PYRUS.

PYRUS

PLEASE GET DIRTY WITH ME.

Pyrus drags Parsley to the dance floor.

PARSLEY & PYRUS

LET'S GET DIRTY!

DJ CAULIFLOWER

YOU: I GOT, I GOT DIRT
ON YOU, ON YOU.
YOU GOTTA LOTTA NERVES COMING HERE.

Pyrus hands a bottle to Parsley. He incrementally drinks.

PARSLEY

WITH YOUR CARBON!

DJ CAULIFLOWER

YOU: I GOT, I GOT DIRT
ON YOU, ON YOU.
YOU... I'M KEEPING MY EYES ON YOUR

DJ CAULIFLOWER (CONT'D)
DIRTY SOIL!

PARSLEY & PYRUS
FILTHY SOIL!

PARSLEY

LET'S GET DIRTY!

PYRUS

YA SO DIRTY TO ME!

DJ CAULIFLOWER

Y'ALL GET DIRTY!

PARSLEY & PYRUS

YOU: I GOT, I GOT DIRT
ON YOU, ON YOU, YOU... I'M KEEPING
MY EYES ON YOUR DIRTY SOIL!

DJ CAULIFLOWER
DO NOT MESS AROUND BECAUSE MY ROOTS
ARE IN DA UNDERGROUND.
IF YOU STUCK AROUND, WE'LL HAVE
YOUR STEMS MAKING MUDDY WET SOUNDS.

PARSLEY & PYRUS
ROOT FOR ME
AND WATER ME!

DJ CAULIFLOWER
SOIL ME!
Give me dat freaking money!

Pyrus makes money rain.

PYRUS
Watch the carbs, Dirty City!

PARSLEY
What's dirty?

PYRUS
Dirty City? Where ya live? Are ya-?

PARSLEY
I never felt so aliveeee!

DJ CAULIFLOWER
Dat lil herb's on da own lil island-

Money turns into rain. The ocean descends, washing Pyrus away. Parsley's sea legs break. Fear swallows him.

PARSLEY
CAN A, CAN A PLANT DROWN?

DJ CAULIFLOWER
IF WATER REACHES OUR STEMS, WE IN
TROUBLE
WHEN DA BAR AIN'T YOURS, TIME
BEHIND BARS IS DOUBLED!

PARSLEY
DOUBLED? !

PYRUS (O.S.)
I NEED YOU... YOU NEED TO...
I NEED TO, I NEED TWO BARS OF REST!

DJ Cauliflower cuts the music as Pyrus soon finds Parsley.

	PYRUS (CONT'D)	PARSLEY
Parsley! Parsley!		Py- Pesto-

Parsley pukes. Music resumes. Camera flashes around Parsley.

DJ CAULIFLOWER

Dat's real dirt, did someone get
dat on tape?

PYRUS

Malus is my unty! Ugh. You're good
as dirt, hanging with the grapes.

DJ CAULIFLOWER

Plz. My hype men are homemade! Now,
compost dat on all social medias!

DO NOT MESS AROUND BECAUSE MY ROOTS
ARE IN DA UNDERGROUND.
NOW YOU'VE STUCK AROUND, WE'LL HAVE
YOUR STEMS IMPOUND IMPOUND IMPOUND!

PYRUS

DIRT'S ON YA...

PARSLEY

AND DIRT'S ON YOU...

DJ CAULIFLOWER

CALL DA COPS!

PARSLEY & PYRUS

BROCCOLIS?!

DJ CAULIFLOWER

YOU: WE GOT, WE GOT DIRT
ON BOTH OF YOU
YA GOTTA LOTTA NERVES DRINKING HERE

PYRUS

THIS IS BULL CRAP!

Pyrus drags away Parsley. There are police lights and sirens.

DJ CAULIFLOWER

YOU: WE GOT, WE GOT DIRT
ON YOU, YOU, YOU...
TWO... ARE NOT ABLE TO WIGGLE

DJ CAULIFLOWER (CONT'D)

YOUR WAY OUTTA DIS!

PARSLEY & PYRUS

THERE'S DIRT ON US!

The COPS, all broccolis, enter and HANDCUFF the kids.

END OF "DIRT ON YOU"

DIP TO BLACK:

INT. HOSPITAL HALLWAY - NIGHT

Rau sits on a chair, trembling with anxiety. Malus rushes in.

MALUS
Is Parsley alright?

RAU
He's not going to the light, no
thanks to Pyrus.

MALUS
I'm always here for you, too.

RAU
You've lost an ally.

MALUS
I also lost the plot... FigLeaf is
in trouble. Dirty City's shutting
us down. They got proof.

RAU
The proof in my son's stoma...

MALUS
Underage drinking... Perpetrated-
Encouraged by my own sprout.

Rau holds Malus's hand.

RAU
I'll give my testimony...

Malus smiles. Rau briefly sees visions of Cori Anh dance by.

RAU (CONT'D)
...against you and every Fig.

MALUS
We have more in common with
transplants than you'll ever know.

RAU
I was not born yesterday.

MALUS
I was born on this soil. Yet, it
ain't always green on this side for
me, a Fig.

Malus, looking genuinely hurt, turns and exits.

A NURSE approaches Rau.

NURSE

Your son is now awake if you'd like
to root with him.

INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Rau holds Parsley's hand while he lies in bed. Parsley is
unable to speak with tubes.

RAU

Parsley, did you soil yourself?
Listen to me. You are never allowed
anywhere near Pyrus. Understand?

Parsley stares at her with fear and resentment in his eyes.

INT. SALONTRO - DAY

TEXT: A MONTH LATER...

Parsley sweeps with hollow strokes. Outside the window, the
bus idles. Pyrus and Bombus board. Across the street, Malus
hammers "plywood" over the vibrant doors of FigLeaf.

RAU (O.S.)

Be spotless, Parsley! No dust!

PARSLEY

(to himself)

There's no spot here. But maybe,
there's a spot there. Dust off-

The bus pulls away. Parsley drops the broom.

DIRTY CITY - STREETS - CONTINUOUS

Parsley sprints down the road, chasing the bus's exhaust. It
pulls ahead.

The mail truck runs over Salontro's mailbox again. The
mailperson (woodpulp) leans out.

MAILPERSON

Need a ride?

Parsley dives into the passenger seat. He points ahead.

PARSLEY

Follow that bus!

MAILPERSON

Part and parcel, Parsley.

INT. BUS - MOMENTS LATER

The mail truck pulls alongside the moving bus.

MAILPERSON
Special delivery!

BOMBUS
Bzzz.

Parsley leaps from the truck. He nearly slips, but Bombus nabs his overalls, hauling him through the open bus window and onto the seat next to a stunned Pyrus.

Pyrus! PARSLEY Parsley?! PYRUS

The kids embrace.

PYRUS (CONT'D)
What will your mom say?

RAU (PRE-LAP)
Parsley!

INT. SALONTRO - CONTINUOUS

RAU enters the main salon. The broom lies abandoned. The front door swings wide in the wind.

MONTAGE:

- Rau paces the salon, a phone to her ear. "My son's missing! Parsley Ram! He's green... everyone's green! He's an herb!"

- Night falls. Rau stands under a streetlamp, clutching a stack of "Missing" flyers.

- Rau sits in her office, staring at her own Green Card. It feels heavy and worthless.

- Rau collapses on the salon floor, surrounded by darkness.
She let out a broken sob.

END MONTAGE

PRE-LAP: The cries of children.

EXT. DIRTY CITY - NIGHT

An armored SAPP vehicle idles. Agents toss a family of YUCCA VALIDAS into the back. The steel doors SLAM shut.

Nearby, Rhizo checks off a name in the booklet Rau gave them.

RHIZO

We got the Validas. Next transplant-

MONTAGE: UPROOTING

- EXT. TERRACOTTA POTHOUSE: Rhizo kicks in a door. Dirt spills out. Agents drag out a transplant family.
- EXT. STREET: Agents detain herbs on the corner.
- INT. APARTMENT: Agents drag a weeping vine out the door.
- EXT. STREET: An armored truck slams shut, muffling cries.
- Rhizo crosses out name after name in the booklet.

SAPP AGENTS (V.O.)

Uproot! Uproot! Uproot! Uproot!

RHIZO (V.O.)

The best part is no one shall see
us do this in the shadows.

BOOM. Rhizo breaks into another terracotta pothouse.

END MONTAGE

INT. RAU'S OFFICE IN SALONTRO - NIGHT

Rau sits in the dark. On her TV, a muted news feed shows a declining population graph. The Mayor sadly speaks at press announcements. CHYRON: "DIRTY CITY RAMPS UP UPROOTS."

RAU

Everything's on fire because of me.

She slams her head onto the desk. The herbal model of Cori Anh topples, falling into an open drawer. Rau reaches in to retrieve it, but her hand finds a thick CALENDAR instead.

"TAKE YOUR PICK" SONG

Rau puts the calendar on the wall. It's a mosaic of daily polaroids, ending abruptly at June 20. She rips them down.

RAU (CONT'D)

CHANGE YOUR LIFE
BY KNOWING WHICH IS WHICH
CHOOSE YOUR SMILE
TAKE YOUR PICK

She fans the photos like a flipbook. We see Parsley grow from a sprout into a more discontent boy. She stops at the photo from Cantaloupe Outlets. Parsley and Pyrus, smiling.

RAU (CONT'D)
CHANGE YOUR LIFE
BY PICKING WHICH
CHOOSE YOUR SMILE
TAKE YOUR PICK

Rau looks at Cori Anh's model. He becomes lively in her mind.
He puts on a crop top and reveals his Fig emblem.

RAU (CONT'D)
Why did you choose to be a Fig?

CORI ANH
A chose? Those you love are born
one.

RAU
Those I love are not born monsters.

CORI ANH
Maybe you'll learn to love an
"unnatural monster" someday.

The vision fades. Rau stares at the photo of Parsley, Pyrus,
Malus, and Bombus.

RAU
My son is not a monster. I am the
one who is unnatural.

She grabs Parsley's camera—the one filled with photos of
SAPP's violence. She scans them, logs into Parsley's social
media, and hits POST.

The view count EXPLODES.

Rau pulls up the City Hall auction site. The next is August
3. "FigLeaf" is on the list.

RAU (CONT'D)
I WILL TAKE THE PICK!

She pins the kids' photo onto the August 3 calendar square.

END OF "TAKE YOUR PICK"

END OF ACT II

ACT III**EXT. CITY HALL - DAY**

A "City Auction" banner hangs outside a government building.

INT. CITY HALL - CONTINUOUS

Wealthy plants pack the room. On stage, COUNT CELERY (70s) points a gavel at an orphanage photo. Next is FigLeaf.

COUNT CELERY

And sold to that fine asparagus
there. Have fun with the orphanage.

Next is FigLeaf. Opening bid?

RAU

One million!

Rau swiftly stands up. The room gasps. Count Celery grins.

COUNT CELERY

Wow! Someone wants to get turned
up. And I don't mean the turnips.
One million. Going once. Twice.

The heavy doors SLAM open. Alton Dandy strides in.

DANDY

One million and one!

COUNT CELERY

It's Alton Dandy of All Dandy
Properties. That dandelion is
always one upping other plants!

RAU

That Dandelion with a fly.

DANDY

Still struggling, herb? It's dandy
to have an off-soil bank account.

COUNT CELERY

Going once. Twice. Sold to Dandy!

DANDY

I cannot wait to bulldoze it and
turn it into another golf course
with artificial grass serving us!

RAU

Guess it's time to roll out Plan B.

PRE-LAP: The sound of breaking into a house.

INT. FIGLEAF - NIGHT

Rau kicks in the door, hauling chains and watering cans.

RAU
Breaking and rooting...

She chains herself to the floor joists beneath the skylight.

TIME JUMP: Sunlight hits Rau's face. She wakes to the THUD of boots. Dandy and a DEMOLITION CREW enter with dynamite.

DANDY
No squatting on a Dandy Properties!

RAU
This plot belongs to the Figs!

DANDY
Prepare to be a figment of my
imagination. Confiscate her water!

RAU
I can wilt, but Figs will never!

The crew STEALS her cans. They march out to a crowd outside.

EXT. FIGLEAF - DAY

A reporter shouts over a swarm of PROTESTORS.

REPORTER
...viral footage of SAPP brutality
has sparked a massive turnout!
Inside, a lone cilantro is chained
in protest for transplant rights-

A group of FIGS sprint past, SNATCHING the microphone..

PROTESTORS
And Figs' rights!

THE BEACH - CONTINUOUS

Rhizo sprawls on a towel. Their radio crackles with the
REPORTER'S VOICE.

REPORTER (RADIO)
You heard it here, fruits and
vegetable. Progress for transplants
and Figs. And a cilantro is leading
this fight.

RHIZO

There's only one cilantro who can
put up a fight. But it can't be...

REPORTER (RADIO)

...one protester got a word from
the leader...

RAU (RADIO)

Smile for the camera, Woodwork!

RHIZO

It is her! My one day off from
uprooting and she's a martyr!

Rhizo BOLTS upright and KICKS the radio into the sand.

INT. FIGLEAF - DUSK

A HELICOPTER CREW boards up the ceiling. Dandy supervises.

RAU

The sky is the limit... But, I have
no limit... with water.

EXT. FIGLEAF - CONTINUOUS

Police vehicles swarm the streets. Cops (mostly Broccolis)
trample protester's tents and water cans. They form a line. A
SAPP truck pulls up. RHIZO steps out with a megaphone.

THE SCREEN SPLITS: Rhizo outside, Rau inside.

RHIZO

Rau!

RAU

Rhizo...

RHIZO

What are you doing? You're above
the soil. You're with the top
plants now. Don't get in the way.

RAU

I love my roots...

RHIZO

I gave you your Green Card, I can
take it away!

RAU

Ha! That's what I tell my son: "I
seed you, I can unseed you!"

RHIZO

Don't come out for the Figs or the
trans. Come out for your patriotic
Woodworkans!

RAU

For once in my life, I will stay
for my friends...

RHIZO

Your green privileges ends...

"LOSE YOUR COLOR"

Rhizo gets Rau's case file and signs the "Termination" line.

INT. FIGLEAF - CONTINUOUS

Rau sees her green hand fades to red. She tries to save the
green to no avail. She checks the card. It burns in her palm.

RAU'S VISION

Cori Anh slips away into the void.

PRE-LAP: The sound of ripping paper.

END OF "LOSE YOUR COLOR"

EXT. FIGLEAF - CONTINUOUS

Rhizo shreds the green card. Dandy holds the megaphone.

RHIZO

Soon as these wildflowers get bored
of the limelight and get out the
way, I WILL PERSONALLY uproot you
and have you deported back to that
muddy garden from whence you came.

The protesters hold their ground.

INT. FIGLEAF - CONTINUOUS

Rau weeps into her red hands. She stares at the photo of her
and Parsley.

EXT. PYRUS'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Pyrus's bedroom is illuminated by a TV.

INT. PYRUS'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Bombus flips channels on a TV remote. Parsley and Pyrus watch.

PARSLEY

How do bees watch TV with five eyes-

PYRUS

Question: How do plants have eyes?

The channel briefly flips to footages of Rau then sports.

PARSLEY

Mom?!

PYRUS

We do get our eyes from our moms...

PARSLEY

No! My mom's on TV! Flip back the channel, Bombus!

Bombus flips from the bee sports channel to WoodTV news.

ANCHOR (TV)

...a defiant cilantro has become an international sensation. She's been without water and light for days...

Bombus flips to a bee sports replay, showing an injured BEE.

BROADCASTER (TV)

Oh! Let's watch the instant replay.

PYRUS

Ya mom's trying to protect FigLeaf?

PARSLEY

She's gonna wilt if she doesn't stop *this instant*.

PYRUS

Ya mom's gonna die?! For FigLeaf?
Do you need a ride?

Parsley tears up.

EXT. ALL DANDY PROPERTIES HEADQUARTERS - NIGHT

The headquarters contain many dandelion-inspired buildings.

DANDY (O.S.)

I thought it would work...

INT. ALL DANDY PROPERTIES CONFERENCE ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Dandy paces back and forth. Rhizo flips through Rau's file.

DANDY

I thought the light-block would
break her.

RHIZO

She survived the Paddy War. A
little shade won't make her wilt.

DANDY

It's a PR nightmare! If she wilts,
my stock drops to the bedrock.

RHIZO

Do you dandelions really need to
own another plot of land?

DANDY

It's the family business.

Rhizo stops at a photo in the file: Parsley and Pyrus at the
salon. He looks at Dandy.

RHIZO

Let's draft a compromise deal.

DANDY

Dandelions don't compromise. We get
a better deal.

RHIZO

It is. If she leaves FigLeaf, you
don't bulldoze. You get your bid
refunded, plus priority on all
future housing developments for the
Department of Garden Security.

DANDY

And the cilantro? Since she's red-
handed again, she can't legally own
that salon.

RHIZO

The salon will be yours.

DANDY

Caught red-handed. All Dandy.

They shake leaves.

INT. FIGLEAF / EXT. FIGLEAF - DAY - INTERCUT

Rau, barely holding on, clutches a photo of the kids.

Outside, a bus screeches to the curb. Parsley, Pyrus, and Bombus hop off. Pyrus elbows through the massive crowd.

PYRUS

Get outta the way, *community*!

At the barricade, the cops block them.

Bombus hoists the kids to the boarded window.

PARSLEY (O.S.)

Me (Viet: "Mom")!

Rau lowers the photo. She sees them. New life surges through her stems. She TEARS her roots from the floorboards and stumbles to the exit.

RAU

Con trai (Viet: "Son")... and
Pyrus...

As Rau emerges into the sunlight, the crowd falls silent. Rhizo and Dandy watch from the bulldozer.

DANDY

She's not dead. But the deal's is!

Rau hugs Parsley. The protestors cheer.

Dandy SHREDS the agreement. Rhizo barks into a megaphone.

RHIZO

Bar the soap! Bar the soap!

The cops seize Rau. The crowd ROARS.

Bombus dives at a protestor's megaphone, emitting a DEAFENING SONIC BUZZ. The cops recoil. Pyrus nabs the megaphone.

PYRUS

(Through the megaphone)
Plants of the law. When did you
kids grow up to be hall monitors?
Isn't it your job to protect
property? The property that have
provided you refuge. I've seen many
of you be your true selves here.
I've seen you all fabulous.

Several cops blush, lowering their batons. They step back, refusing to hold Rau.

PYRUS (CONT'D)

You will amount to anything...

Dandy barks out orders to the BULLDOZER DRIVER.

DANDY
Uproot this alliance!

BULLDOZER DRIVER
Look, uprooting a community-led
peaceful gathering is one thing.
But *the Broccolis*. I'm a transplant-

Rhizo hears the bulldozer driver say they're a transplant.

Dandy shoves the driver out and takes the wheel, dispersing the crowd. They ram FigLeaf. Instead of crushing it, the bulldozer's giant trowel SCOOPS the building, flipping it upside down into a pile of rubble.

Pyrus looks shocked.

RAU
(Sobbing)
All a figment of nothing...

Parsley holds her red hand.

PARSLEY
We still have Salontro.

RAU
Salontro's not mine to own anymore.

PARSLEY
Salontro is not just home to us.

PYRUS
It is home for me...

PARSLEY & PYRUS
...and this community!

RAU
Vamos...

PYRUS
Bombus. Get back up!

Bombus rockets into the sky. The trio head inside Salontro.

EXT. SALONTRO - CONTINUOUS

Two Sapp agents (LANK and BUFF) arrive.

Rhizo pulls off the gloves of the bulldozer driver, revealing blue transplant hands.

RHIZO

Don't want to get my leaves dirty.

Rhizo approaches the emboldened Dandy in the bulldozer.

DANDY

With Salontro, this be a two for
one deal today or what? All Dandy!

RHIZO

I need a word with you about
your... *transgression*.

Rhizo and two agents (Lank and Buff) march towards the salon.

INT. SALONTRO - CONTINUOUS

Rau collapses from exhaustion. Parsley and Pyrus drag her
into the office, slamming the door as the Agents BURST in.

PARSLEY

Mom, please don't wilt.

PYRUS

Wada we do, tutor?

PARSLEY

Give 'em a free tan.

Parsley hands salon tools to Pyrus like weapons.

PYRUS

Ya learning from me.

PARSLEY

Teachers learn most from students.

PYRUS

Tangent...

PARSLEY (CONT'D)

...Secant!

The kids BLIND the Agents with spray and facial cream.

PARSLEY & PYRUS

Complimentary leaf spray?!

LANK

Weed killer?!

BUFF

I'm high... Highly allergic!

PARSLEY & PYRUS

Need to cleanse them pores?!

Lank seizes Parsley.

LANK

Imma put pores in you, sprout!

But Pyrus tricks Buff into punching Lank, causing Lank to land in a tanning bed, unconscious.

PYRUS

Hitting people is wrong!

PARSLEY

But it feels so right!

Pyrus whips Buff's behind with a wet towel, sending them skidding on a puddle of cream. Buff slides across the floor on a service cart and into a second tanning bed. SLAM.

PARSLEY (CONT'D)

Where's the third?

Rhizo emerges from the steam like a ghost.

RHIZO

Seedling Protective Services?!

PARSLEY & PYRUS

Ahhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhh!!!!!!

INT. SALONTRO - MOMENTS LATER

Rhizo handcuffs the kids to the counter.

RHIZO

Where's that invasive species you call "mom?"

PARSLEY

She's living the dream, unlike you!

RHIZO

I dream for our garden nation to be
plotted only by green hands like us-

PYRUS

Hands of all colors are what make
this country fruitful!

RHIZO

It's fruitless, kids. Nothing can change my aldehyde. I change lives.

Rhizo sees a door labeled: "Rau Ram's Office."

The kids insult Rhizo.

INT. RAU'S OFFICE IN SALONTRO - CONTINUOUS

Rhizo enters, finds Rau slumped at her desk. She awakens.

RHIZO (CONT'D)
Living the dream. Stay in it, Rau.

RAU
Your mom would be ashamed of you!

RHIZO
You don't know her.

RAU
As transplants, I know her kind
real well.

RHIZO
And your kind was unkind.

RAU
But you're a child of transplants.

RHIZO
My twin was friends with invasive-

RAU
You'd make friends too if you don't
insult them.

RHIZO
What hurts more than insults were
silence and violence.

Rhizo puts down Rau's head on the desk and handcuffs her.

RHIZO (CONT'D)
You have the right to remain
silent. Not remain here.

Rhizo sees a polaroid camera. They reach for it. FLASH!
They're blinded. Bombus rockets in, KNOCKING them out. MALUS
emerges from the rear door, holding the camera's remote.

MALUS
Need your keys back, darling?

RAU
The angel came back right on time.
How were you so stealthy?

MALUS
Agent Orange taught me a thing or
two. Like flashing.

INT. SALONTRO - MOMENTS LATER

Bombus uses their stinger to unlock the kids' handcuffs.

Malus shoves Rhizo into a tanning bed.

From inside the tanning bed, Rhizo sees the light.

BEGIN FLASHBACK

Teenage transplants with non-green hands beat up 8-year-old Rhizo. 8-year-old Canna stops the bullies.

That night, their MOTHER holds Rhizo's head high with her non-green hands. Their mother heals Rhizo's wounds with light.

We see young Canna proudly look at young Rhizo.

MATCH CUT TO:**END FLASHBACK**

Canna opens the bed, ready to fight, but Rhizo hugs instead.

CANNA

I came to talk some sense. Is it no longer necessary? You take bribes?

RHIZO

I saw the light.

Rau holds up a fresh polaroid of Rhizo's "light" moment.

RAU

Before photo. How about an after?

RHIZO

Don't expect a green card anytime soon. Just expect a home here for the time being.

RAU

Expect two proud mothers.

Rhizo finally shakes Rau's hand. FLASH!

EXT. SALONTRO - MOMENTS LATER

Rhizo and Canna exit. Rhizo clutches the polaroids. Dandy revs the bulldozer, aimed at the salon's front window.

Dandy prepares to drive the bulldozer into Salontro.

DANDY

You got your twin on our side?!
Another two-for-one deal!

RHIZO

You broke our deal with your
invasive species.

CANNA

Transplants.

RHIZO

How many *transplants* is your
company harboring and exploiting?

DANDY

That's what you meant by
"transgression..."

Rhizo signals. The two tanned Sapp Agents emerge from the
salon and SLAM handcuffs onto Dandy's stalks.

INT. SALONTRO - EVENING

The dust settles. The salon is a mess of cream and towels.

RAU

I'm sorry I couldn't save Fig-

MALUS

(Motioning to Pyrus)
Save your energy, darling. You
saved what matters.

PYRUS

I still don't amount to anything.

PARSLEY

(Nudging Pyrus)
You mounted a revolution, poop-head-

Rau rolls her eyes and looks at the cash register.

RAU

Such foul mouth- Anywho, I wasn't
finished. I can't save the old
FigLeaf. But I can save you a spot
right here for the new one.

Rau gestures to the empty plot. The group (Rau, Parslsey,
Pyrus, Malus, Bombus) pull into a tight, leafy embrace.

EXT. SALONTRO - CONTINUOUS

The sun sets over the wreckage. FigLeaf is a pile of rubble, but the foundation remains.

MALUS (V.O.)

A cilantro with a heart? Now I've seen everything.

RAU (V.O.)

Don't get used to it, Apple. I've still got a business to run.

EXT. SALONTRO - DAY

The salon neighbors a construction site with a FRESH PLOT.

TEXT: END OF THE SUMMER.

INT. SALONTRO - CONTINUOUS

Rau gazes out at the FigLeaf construction site. Beside her, the cash register is empty, except a single bill.

PYRUS

Slow day, Ms. Ram?

RAU

Quiet day. A good problem to have.

PYRUS

Like me? Too bad you can't legally own the place without a card.

PARSLEY (O.S.)

But I can!

Parsley hangs the deed. His name is scribbled over Rau's.

PYRUS

Local age laws. The Mayor...?

Rau nods, haphazardly.

The bus HISSES to a stop outside. Bombus lands on Pyrus's head.

PYRUS (CONT'D)

Welp, time to mind my own beeswax.

RAU

Go back to school. Get As not Bs.

Bombus gets the joke, acknowledging it with their antenna.

PYRUS

I need school, so I don't end up a
"đồ vô học" ("dough vo how"; Viet:
"An uneducated person"). Sorry for
calling ya an invader.

RAU

I'm not who you should be sorry to.

PYRUS

Little herb... I... Sor-

PARSLEY

Breathe in, breathe out... Um, six
carbon... Twelve hydrogen... Six
oxygen...

PYRUS

Plus six oxygen molecules...

PARSLEY & PYRUS

Photosynthesis. Photosynthesis.
Photo- I will always root for you.

They share a quick, fierce hug. Pyrus shoves a fresh CROP TOP
into Parsley's hands.

PYRUS

Don't puke on this one, okay?

PARSLEY

And don't let the flowers bully
you!

RAU

Wait!

Rau hands Pyrus the single bill.

RAU (CONT'D)

A debt settled in sugar. I owe your
unty. Salontro is starting an
internship and we'd like you to be
our first intern.

PYRUS

I'd probably get the salon shut
down, too.

PARSLEY

Oh shut up, poop head.

"TURNOVER (A NEW LEAF)" SONG

PYRUS

I'd be supervised by *dat*? I'll
clean dat dirt in ya mouth, ya
sweetgrass.

RAU

Finally, someone else up for the
task.

PYRUS

I cannot thank you enough, Ms. Ram.

RAU

It's my *turn* to help you start
over.

PARSLEY

You're welcome back any time!

RAU

With Malus's intent, there's always
a plot for you here.

Rau opens a colorful tanning bed, for Pyrus to sit and gleam.

Malus radiantly emerges from a neighboring bed.

MALUS

TURN AROUND!

The doors of the salon fly open as a crowd of multicultural
patrons floods in.

PARSLEY & PYRUS

WE HAVE CHANGED THEM
TURN OVER PAIRS OF FRESH EYES
NEW LEAVES, COLORS
TURN OVER TO THIS STRANGE LIGHT

RAU & MALUS

LIGHT

PARSLEY, RAU, PYRUS, MALUS

THIS DIRTY CITY IS OUR HOME
THE NEIGHBORS, THEY'RE KNOWN
TO HELP US TO SOW OUR SEEDS AND
GROW...
TURN OVER AND CHANGE FOR THE BETTER

Rain falls outside, shimmering like glitter. Through the
window, Rau sees a vision of her younger self and Cori Anh
dancing on the site of the new FigLeaf.

PARSLEY & RAU
THIS IS THE SPARK OF...
A FLORAL PARTNERSHIP.
A FRIENDSHIP WHERE I CAN REST
OUR GARDEN.

PYRUS & MALUS
THIS IS THE SPARK OF...
AN HERBAL PARTNERSHIP.
A FRIENDSHIP THAT LEAVES THE
BEST SHARED GARDEN.

Parsley and Pyrus flip the sign to OPEN.

PARSLEY, RAU, MALUS, PYRUS
BUT THE BEST TURNOVER WE'VE HAD IS
THE SUN!

A tanning bed opens, emitting a blinding sunlight that fills
the screen. Bombus zips towards us.

END OF "TURNOVER (A NEW LEAF)"

END OF ACT III

DIP TO WHITE:

EXT. DIRTY CITY - DAY

Canna, Rau, Malus, the kids, and a crowd of townsfolk lead a
parade towards the camera.

THROUGH THE CAMERA:

CANNA
(to us)
We hope you enjoyed your stay in
Dirty City. Have a safe trip home.
We're rooting for you! Oh, and
before you return to your home
garden, let's take a group photo!

"BOW - PHOTOSYNTHESIS" SONG

COMPANY
PHOTOSYNTHESIS! PHOTOSYNTHESIS!
PHOTO!

END OF "BOW - PHOTOSYNTHESIS"

FLASH!

The polaroid camera PRINTS the final photo. It's the perfect
group photo with the community that Rau dreamed of since her
lonely photo in the customs office.

Below reads the end title: PHOTOSYNTHESIS (QUANG HOP).

END OF THE PLOT

CREDITS

DEDICATION: DEDICATED TO HUE NGOC NGUYEN, PHOTOGRAPHER,
GARDENER, AND DAVID QUANG PHAM'S MOM



The credits include real-life animation production photos or memories from *Turnover: A New Leaf* theatre performances.